

The Promise and Limits of Leader-Driven Grassroots Campaigns*

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Abstract

Opposition parties struggle against populist incumbents who portray them as elite and out of touch, while often consolidating power and tilting electoral politics in their favor. We conceptualize and examine leader-driven grassroots campaigns as an electoral strategy for opposition parties facing populists. We study this tactic by focusing on the Indian National Congress leader’s 150-day Bharat Jodo Yatra. Using newly collected election data and a difference-in-differences design, we estimate the effect of direct geographic exposure to the yatra on Congress’s vote share in subsequent elections. We find that yatra exposure helped Congress, though in spatially and temporally limited ways. Interviews and descriptive evidence demonstrate that the yatra improved the opposition’s image and helped them break through the pro-incumbent environment. An original survey reveals that yatra participants experienced longer-term positive impacts. The findings underscore how leader-driven grassroots campaigns can address the challenges that opposition parties face when competing against populist incumbents.

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1 Introduction

Populist leaders have risen to power across regions, often portraying themselves as authentic representatives of the masses in opposition to corrupt elites aligned with established parties (Mudde 2004). Once in power, populists can undermine democratic institutions from within, reshaping institutional rules to consolidate and preserve their power (Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018; Weyland 2024). Even when not overtly anti-democratic, such leaders commonly engage in illiberal practices that erode democratic norms and protections (Krastev 2007; Mudde 2019). Increasingly, scholars have studied ways to counteract this rise in populism and its associated democratic backsliding, ranging from aggressive or extra-institutional actions (Bourne 2023; Gamboa 2023) such as protests or even coups to more institutional responses, including coalition-building (Samet 2024; Ong 2022) and judicial intervention (Cleary and Öztürk 2022; Gamboa, García-Holgado and González-Ocantos 2024). Perhaps the most obvious yet elusive approach is for the opposition party to defeat the populist at the ballot box. Weyland (2025) notes “elections are, in principle, even more decisive by allowing for the termination of populist tenure and the recovery of liberal pluralism.” However, successful electioneering against an incumbent populist is challenging. Opposition parties often struggle with the pervasive narrative that they are out of touch with voters, face exclusion from mainstream media platforms, and are widely perceived as electorally nonviable due to the consolidated dominance of populist incumbents. This raises a critical yet underexplored question: How can opposition parties challenge the populist incumbent at the ballot box?

We identify a key strategy that is increasingly employed by opposition parties that confront populist incumbents: leader-driven grassroots campaigns. This form of party-voter interaction involves costly and atypical outreach by party leaders to engage with citizens directly, articulating an ideological vision, and listening to voter concerns. Although such campaigns can be used for party-building and electoral mobilization, opposition leaders have increasingly deployed them to address the specific disadvantages they face when competing against populist parties. These campaigns seek to counter negative narratives about the opposition, foster direct and personalized connections with citizens, and improve the perceived electoral viability of the party. From Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu’s Republican People’s Party (CHP) in Turkey and Lula da Silva’s Workers Party in Brazil to Freeman Mbowe’s Chadema in Tanzania and Peter Magyar’s Tisza Party in Hungary, opposition parties across diverse contexts have adopted this electoral tactic in response to populist parties and their accompanying illiberal action. This paper conceptualizes leader-driven grassroots campaigns, theorizes the mechanisms through which they help opposition parties facing populist incumbents, and provides quantitative and qualitative evidence on the electoral consequences of this strategy.

We study this tactic in the context of India, where the opposition Indian National Congress (INC) sought to counter its entrenched out-of-touch reputation and mobilize support following two consecutive national losses to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and electoral setbacks across several states. The BJP used a populist strategy that effectively branded the Congress as inept, corrupt, and elitist, exacerbating the continued decline of the party (Naseemullah and Chhibber 2024; Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021). While not at the same level as some populists in Europe and Latin America, the party has nonetheless engaged in tactics, including media suppression, exploiting electoral finance regulations, and mobilizing anti-minority sentiment (Varshney 2022; Tudor 2023; Allie 2025). In response, Congress Party leader Rahul Gandhi undertook a 150-day-long march, the Bharat Jodo Yatra (“Unite India March”), across India with the stated goal of uniting the country, listening to citizen concerns, and pitching an alternative vision for the idea of India. The Bharat Jodo Yatra (hereafter referred to as BJY or the yatra) represented a leader-driven grassroots campaign similar to other efforts taken by opposition leaders facing populist incumbents, such as the Justice March in Turkey and the March of One Million Steps in Hungary.

We analyze how voter exposure to and participation in the yatra impacted their political behavior and ultimately the electoral prospects of the Congress Party.¹ Using the party’s social media and official daily reports, we reconstruct the BJY’s route across India and validate it with party officials. We merge this data with state and national election data. Our main specification uses a difference-in-differences design to examine the impact of the yatra. The design relies on the idea that while constituencies where the yatra did and did not pass through are certainly different from one another, absent the yatra, both types of constituencies would have followed a parallel trajectory in their electoral outcomes. As a robustness exercise, we also estimate this design on a matched sample of treated and control constituencies based on pre-treatment electoral and political characteristics.

We find that constituencies exposed to the BJY experienced an average increase of approximately 4 percentage points in Congress vote share in proximate state elections. While the national elections held eighteen months later show no overall effect, the march yielded significant gains, between 2.3 and 3.0 percentage points, in states where Congress was the principal opposition to the BJP. These estimates are comparable when using the matched sample, underscoring that the results are not driven by pre-existing differences between yatra

¹News articles have pointed to the impact of the yatra (See Hindustan Times). Verma and Pratikshit (2024) discusses the role of the yatra as part of Congress’s broader 2024 election strategy and Choudhary and Mishra (2024) begin to examine the impact of the yatra by comparing the 2019 and 2024 national elections. This paper moves beyond this existing work by theorizing the broader category of campaigns that the yatra is an example of, estimating the impact of the yatra in state and national elections, and investigating the mechanisms by which the yatra influenced political behavior through interviews and an original survey.

and non-yatra constituencies. To further understand the impact of voter exposure to the yatra, we use geo-located polling station-level election results across two election cycles in the first state to hold an election after the yatra concluded (where we found overall effects in our first analysis). Across several empirical approaches, we find that the electoral impact of the yatra was concentrated in polling stations located very close to the route. Together, the observational analyses reveal that the yatra improved Congress’s vote share but only under specific conditions: when elections were temporally proximate, when constituencies were spatially near the yatra route, and when Congress was the central opposition party.

Through interviews with Congress officials and voters, Google Search trends, and descriptive data on follow-up rallies, we argue that leader-driven grassroots campaigns like the yatra can be particularly effective when used by opposition parties against populist incumbents because they address three key problems that the opposition faces in these contexts: an elite narrative, a pro-incumbent political environment, and perceptions of poor viability.

We then investigate the individual-level impact of the yatra by studying participation in the yatra through an original telephone survey of 3510 voters. We find that voters from across the political spectrum participated in the yatra and that respondents who participated in the yatra reported improved perceptions of the opposition, increased discourse about the Congress party, and higher engagement with the Congress party in the year after the yatra. The results underscore that leader-driven grassroots campaigns are capable of reaching voters who previously supported the populist party and can generate durable improvements, even a year after the campaign, with voters who were directly engaged with the grassroots campaign.

This paper makes several contributions. We contribute to a nascent but growing body of literature on how opposition parties can respond to populism and its associated democratic backsliding (Gamboa 2023; Cleary and Öztürk 2022; McCoy and Somer 2021; Riedl et al. 2024). The paper highlights how leader-driven grassroots mobilization can work as an electioneering tactic to specifically counter the challenges that populists create for the opposition. Second, while a great deal of research uses campaigns as a way to understand ethnic politics and clientelism in developing democracies (Ferree 2010; Posner 2005; Horowitz 2016; Arriola et al. 2024; Szwarcberg 2012), this paper joins recent work that studies party campaigning in its own right in the Global South (Paget 2019; Brierley and Kramon 2020; Goyal 2024; Sheikh 2024). It also underscores that campaign tactics that are costly and atypical can break through to voters beyond the standard electioneering strategies. Finally, with the resurgence of populism worldwide, scholars have largely focused on Latin America and Europe. This paper joins recent research on populism in South Asia (Subramanian 2007; Chacko 2018; Naseemullah and Chhibber 2024; Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021) but moves beyond the rise of populism to focus on opposition responses to it. In the

context of India, while extensive research considers the decline of the Congress Party (Chhibber 2001; Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019; Hasan 2012; Dasgupta 2018; Jaffrelot and Kumar 2012), their attempts to rebuild are understudied. This paper examines the most recent high-profile attempt by the Congress leadership to mobilize mass support.

2 Theoretical Perspectives

This section first defines leader-driven grassroots campaigns and their key characteristics. While we note that this strategy can be used by any political party (i.e., incumbent or opposition), we theorize how it can be particularly useful in addressing three key challenges that opposition parties face when competing against a populist incumbent: the perception that the opposition is elite and out of touch, the pro-incumbent political ecosystem, and the view that the opposition lacks viability.

2.1 Conceptualizing Leader-Driven Grassroots Campaigns

Leader-driven grassroots campaigns are a form of party-voter interaction where a party leader engages in extraordinary effort to reach citizens directly with a non-electoral message. At first glance, the strategy of a leader-driven grassroots campaign might appear paradoxical. On the one hand, the campaign is led from the top down by a prominent political leader; on the other hand, it involves bottom-up grassroots mobilization and citizen engagement. However, it is precisely the blending of centralized party leadership and mass-level participation that defines their core dynamic.

More specifically, we conceptualize leader-driven grassroots campaigns as follows. First, the *key party actor* of this campaign is the party leader as opposed to a candidate or members of the party organization. This helps the campaign resonate beyond a particular constituency or candidate. Second, the *voter audience* of these campaigns is all citizens, rather than just supporters. Leader-driven grassroots campaigns involve the leader seeking to engage a broad set of citizens. Third, the *pitch* of this type of party-voter event is non-electoral. While political parties always have electoral goals when engaging with voters, their explicit pitch of what they are doing matters. For example, during leader-driven grassroots campaigns, the party often uses ideological or societal messaging rather than common electoral messages. Moreover, leader-driven grassroots campaigns often occur outside of the normal election campaign cycle. The party intentionally exploits the ostensibly non-electoral nature to make a broader ideological case about the value of the party. Fourth, in terms of *typicality*, a leader-driven grassroots campaign is very atypical. The event itself is rare and involves a leader taking the time to reach out to voters in an extraordinary manner, in contrast to

commonplace events like rallies and canvassing. This type of engagement is time-intensive and seemingly inefficient; however, it is precisely those qualities that allow the event to have a broader scope for impact. In fact, the extraordinary nature makes clear to voters how much effort the party leader is putting in to engage with citizens. In the Appendix A, we differentiate these campaigns from other forms of party-voter engagement, such as rallies, canvassing, and town halls.

2.2 Addressing Opposition Challenges

Leader-driven grassroots campaigns can help *any* party engage in party building and voter engagement. However, we argue that because these campaigns address key challenges that opposition parties face when contesting elections against democracy-eroding populists, they are often used by opposition parties, as is seen across cases from Hungary and Brazil to Tanzania and Turkey. We discuss each challenge and how a leader-driven grassroots campaign directly addresses it.

2.2.1 An Elite Narrative

Central to populist ideology is a binary moral division between “the pure people” and “the corrupt elite” (Mudde 2004). Populists argue that their opposition represents elite interests and is disconnected from the mass public. In Brazil, Jair Bolsonaro branded the Workers’ Party as corrupt elites on his path to victory (Hunter and Power 2019). In the United States, Trump positioned establishment Democratic elites as having betrayed “true members of the nation in favor of minorities, immigrants, and other putative outsiders” (Bonikowski 2019, 11). In power, populists continue to deploy this elite-versus-people rhetoric to delegitimize opposition forces. The persistence of this framing constrains the opposition’s ability to reclaim credibility and rebuild electoral support.

In response to this elite framing, opposition leaders must actively reconnect with voters and demonstrate responsiveness to the concerns of the general public in a costly and meaningful way. Leader-driven grassroots campaigns offer this because they involve the leader traveling extensively across the country, meeting voters in their communities, and listening to their concerns and grievances. In the 2020 election in Tanzania, Freeman Mbowe, the chairman of the opposition party Chadema, engaged in this type of campaign. The ruling CCM under John Magufuli in Tanzania employed populist “elite versus the masses” rhetoric along with engaging in democratic backsliding tactics (Paget 2019). Mbowe’s “walking rallies” in which he connected directly with citizens on the ground, sought to counter the opposition’s elite image. When he was stopped by police forces, he said “how can I not speak to the

people while they stop me and want to speak with me” highlighting his effort to connect with citizens while security forces wanted to stop him (Kwayu 2023, 266). Similarly, in Brazil, Lula da Silva’s Caravan of Hope tour was designed to listen to citizens and mobilize grassroots support in response to the incumbent populist. ²

2.2.2 Pro-Incumbent Political Environment

The opposition faces challenges in voter outreach due to attempts by populists, particularly those with undemocratic tendencies, to control the political ecosystem. When in power, populist parties often concentrate control over the media and undermine independent outlets. For example, Fidesz in Hungary used laws to marginalize or eliminate critical media outlets and the PiS in Poland attacked public media, ultimately placing it under partisan control to use for propaganda (Grzymala-Busse 2019). In India, under Modi, major news networks frequently avoid criticizing the ruling party, constrained by threats of state harassment and financial retaliation (Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019). At the same time, allied business elites also acquired previously independent television channels, tightening the ruling party’s grip over the media landscape. This weakened the opposition’s ability to communicate with the public and articulate a compelling alternative.

Leader-driven grassroots campaigns can generate critical visibility and public attention for opposition parties in environments where populist incumbents have monopolized or suppressed independent media. When opposition leaders march across the country, it is often a spectacle that generates coverage both within and outside the country, even if the populist-controlled media ignore it. During the Justice March in Turkey, while the state-run media highlighted the march as a threat to public order, independent and international media provided favorable coverage and segments of the march were live-streamed across social media platforms. In May 2025, Peter Magyar from the Tisza Party, the key opposition to Orban’s Fidesz in Hungary, walked 300 kilometers from Budapest to Oradea, Romania as part of the One Million Steps March. The effort drew widespread media attention in a constrained pro-Fidesz environment, engaged Hungarians in Romania who often vote in Hungarian elections, and led to reports that Tisza would have enough support to defeat Fidesz today. The coverage of these marches allowed the opposition to break through restrictive media and reach a wider audience.

2.2.3 Perceptions of Poor Viability

When populist incumbents undertake democracy-eroding actions, voters may come to see their victory as inevitable, further dampening the opposition’s prospects of winning

²Lula Goes Back to His Roots in Effort to Win Once Again Brazil’s Presidency

back voters. Populists are often known to systematically manipulate elections by tilting the electoral playing field in their favor in a way that is not obviously fraudulent (Bermeo 2016). This involves actions such as unequal access to campaign finance, administrative interference in voter registration, and the intimidation or legal persecution of opposition candidates. When populist incumbents pursue these strategies, they can foster a sense of futility among opposition supporters, signaling that electoral competition is meaningless or unwinnable. For example, in the lead-up to Turkey’s 2023 elections, Erdoğan used legal charges to ban the prominent Istanbul mayor from contesting for national office. While the mayor appealed the decision, the opposition ultimately refrained from nominating him as their presidential candidate, signaling opposition weakness (Esen and Gumuscu 2023).

Leader-driven grassroots campaigns can suggest to voters that the opposition is indeed viable even in a tilted electoral playing field. An opposition leader traveling across broad geographic regions can communicate the presence of party infrastructure and organizational strength. For example, Chadema’s walking rallies in Tanzania were perceived as only possible due to the party’s deep grassroots-level efforts (Kwayu 2023). Similarly, Lula’s Caravan of Hope was seen as returning to the grassroots mobilization that originally forged the Worker Party from a mass movement (Keck 1986). By engaging in a leader-driven grassroots campaign, opposition parties can demonstrate the party’s organizational capacity and present themselves as credible alternatives to populist incumbents.

Across aforementioned contexts, opposition parties have employed leader-driven grassroots mobilization in their electoral efforts to defeat a populist party, particularly one engaged in democratic erosion. This tactic is not unique to opposition parties or parties facing a populist, but it is often used in this context because it addresses the core challenges that the opposition faces when taking on a populist, which we outlined above. Moreover, by nature of not being in government, opposition parties lack access to executive resources, patronage, and institutional levers that could be used to influence voters, making these campaigns attractive.

While opposition parties across contexts use leader-driven grassroots campaigns, their electoral effect is underexplored. Because these campaigns address several key challenges that the opposition faces, they may help produce electoral gains. However, several factors could limit this potential impact. First, the populist incumbent’s grip on their voter base may be too entrenched for such campaigns to significantly sway public opinion. Second, swing voters, those most likely to shift allegiance, may not actively participate in these grassroots efforts, which instead might primarily engage individuals already aligned with the opposition. Furthermore, realizing substantive gains from leader-driven grassroots mobilization likely requires sustained engagement rather than a large-scale but one-time effort. These

countervailing dynamics create ambiguous expectations regarding both the effectiveness of these campaigns in altering electoral outcomes and the conditions under which their impact might be limited.

3 Context: The Indian National Congress and the Bharat Jodo Yatra

We examine how the opposition Congress Party sought to make electoral inroads against the BJP through Rahul Gandhi’s leader-driven grassroots campaigns, the Bharat Jodo Yatra.

The BJP under Prime Minister Narendra Modi exhibited common elements of populism. In the 2014 election, Modi framed the Congress Party as corrupt and elite and himself as the authentic voice of the masses (Jaffrelot 2021). By 2019, when the BJP won its second victory, Modi continued to pitch himself as representing the masses, which was increasingly pitched as the Hindu majority, further highlighting the party’s Hindu nationalist ideology (Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021; Leidig and Mudde 2023). Alongside anti-minority rhetoric, the BJP curtailed space for dissent by tightening control over civil society and the press and enacting changes to campaign finance regulations that disproportionately advantaged the ruling party (Tudor 2023; Varshney 2022). In this context, opposition parties, especially the Congress, entered the 2024 national elections and several key state contests facing formidable constraints.³

Under these circumstances, Rahul Gandhi traveled over 4,000 kilometers (approximately 2,500 miles) on foot for over 150 days, starting in September 2022 in Tamil Nadu and ending in January 2023 in Jammu and Kashmir as part of the BJY. We conceptualize the yatra as a leader-driven grassroots campaign. The yatra’s key actor was Rahul Gandhi, the most prominent leader of the Congress Party. The voter audience involved all citizens, not just Congress supporters, as Gandhi walked across the country to meet a wide range of citizens. The BJY had an explicitly non-electoral pitch. It was conducted outside of a formal campaign period, with the closest state election being 7 months away. In fact, while state elections were held in Gujarat during December 2022, when the yatra was taking place, the march did not cross that state at all. Moreover, Gandhi described the campaign as an effort to listen to citizens’ concerns and present an “alternate vision for the idea of India” rather than an electoral campaign.⁴ While (pada)yatras, or marches on foot, hold historical importance in India, the yatra remained atypical and extraordinary. Perhaps the most famous yatra remains Mahatma Gandhi’s Dandi March in 1930, a non-violent protest against

³In Appendix B we provide additional context on Congress’ decline and the rise of the BJP.

⁴BBC - Bharat Jodo Yatra: Rahul Gandhi’s unity march ends in Kashmir

the British salt tax that galvanized mass participation and drew international attention to India’s independence movement (Bhavnani and Jha 2014). Politicians have employed this tactic over time, such as L.K. Advani’s Rath Yatra in 1990 that expanded the BJP’s political base; however, it still represents a costly effort from a political leader (Blakeslee 2018). In the case of the BJY, the event was especially seen as atypical because Rahul Gandhi had never engaged in this form of mobilization before and was, in fact, often criticized by his political opponents for being frequently outside the country.

4 Data and Empirical Approach

In this section, we outline our data collection procedures and research design. Our main analysis estimates the causal impact of the yatra on electoral support for the Congress. Given our interest in both the promise and limits of this strategy, we also examine extent to which its impact is temporally and geographically bounded.

4.1 Bharat Jodo Yatra Route

Using official online sources from the Congress Party and triangulating with social media coverage and official daily party accounts, we construct a continuous route of over 4,000 kilometers traveled by the yatra from September 7, 2022, to January 30, 2023. We then validated our route with INC officials. In Appendix C we provide more details on the data collection and construction of the yatra route. We use this route (shown in Figure 1) to identify “treated” electoral constituencies or places where the yatra crossed.

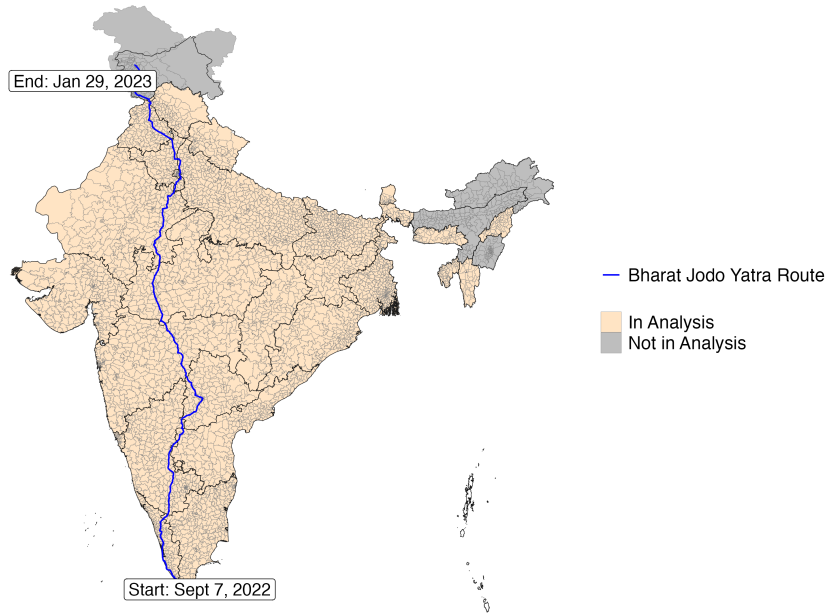


Figure 1: BJY Route and States in Analysis

The process of selecting the yatra route was not random, but rather involved input from Rahul Gandhi, Congress leaders, and members of the party organization. In Appendix D, Tables D.1 and D.2, we show how yatra and non-yatra constituencies differ based on variables from the election prior to the yatra for both state and national elections. In both state and national elections, yatra constituencies had significantly higher Congress vote share. In national elections, yatra constituencies were also more likely to experience a Congress win. Interviews with Congress party functionaries corroborate this, emphasizing that the yatra focused on places where voters “could be receptive to the party.”⁵ Local party leaders in places with a strong party organization lobbied for the yatra in their area and state leaders lobbied for the yatra to spend longer in their state. At the same time, because the yatra traveled along a major highway where a large group of people could march, some locations were also selected for convenience. Due to the inherent differences where the yatra did and did not travel, our empirical approach does not rely on the claim that the yatra route was random.

4.2 Congress Electoral Performance

We examine the impact of the yatra on Congress’s electoral performance in state and national elections. We focus on state elections in five states with elections after the yatra

⁵Author interview with Congress leader. January 7, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

and on the 2024 national elections. Figure 2 presents a timeline of the yatra and the relevant elections .

We restrict our analysis to elections held after 2008 to ensure comparable constituencies within an electoral delimitation. For state elections, we scrape the most recent assembly constituency-level (AC) results from the Election Commission of India and obtain the previous electoral data come from the Trivedi Centre for Political Data (TCDP) (Agarwal et al. 2022). For the main national-level analysis, we use data at the AC level as well, allowing more fine-grained data than results at the parliamentary constituency level.⁶ We manually collect the vote share for the Congress candidate for each assembly constituency from each state-level Election Commission website for the most recent national elections and obtain the prior AC-level results from TCDP. In Appendix C we provide additional details on the election data.

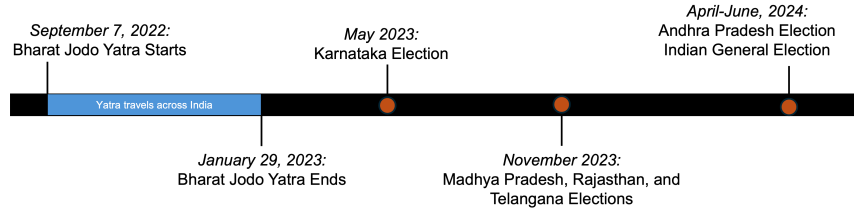


Figure 2: Timeline of BJY and Elections

4.3 Research Design

We estimate the average effect of direct geographic exposure to the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress vote share in subsequent elections, relative to the counterfactual change that would have occurred in the same constituencies had the yatra not passed through them, under the assumption of parallel trends. Our analysis relies on a standard difference-in-differences framework:

$$Y_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{BJY}_i \times \text{Post}_t) + \gamma_i + \theta_t + \delta_s \times t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

Y_{it} denotes vote share for Congress in constituency i during election year t . BJY_i dummy takes the value 1 if the yatra passes through constituency i . Post_t equals 1 if the election was held after the yatra. γ_i and θ_t are constituency and election year fixed effects, respectively. In analyses that pool multiple states (notably the national election analysis), we additionally include state-specific linear time trends, $\delta_s \times t$, to account for state-level factors that may

⁶There are 543 parliamentary constituencies (PC) in India with 5-9 ACs per PC.

evolve differently over time. Standard errors are clustered at the AC level, which is the level at which treatment is defined. The coefficient of interest, β_1 , captures the average effect of direct yatra exposure on Congress vote share. In additional analyses reported in the Appendix, we also operationalize treatment using distance to the yatra route and demonstrate robustness to Conley standard errors that account for spatial correlation.

The identification strategy does not rely on the yatra route being randomly assigned. The identifying assumption is that, conditional on constituency fixed effects, election-year fixed effects, and state-specific linear trends where applicable, Congress vote share in yatra and non-yatra constituencies would have evolved similarly in the absence of the yatra. Because constituencies along the yatra route differ systematically from those not visited, we supplement the baseline difference-in-differences design with a matched difference-in-differences analysis that restricts comparisons to constituencies with similar pre-yatra electoral and demographic characteristics. Importantly, the matching procedure does not alter the identifying assumption of parallel trends, but instead reduces reliance on extrapolation by limiting comparisons to more similar units.

We also report results for Congress electoral victory as an outcome variable in the Appendix (Tables E.2 and E.4).

5 The Electoral Impact of the Bharat Jodo Yatra

We test how exposure to the yatra impacted the electoral outcomes for the Congress party in state and national elections. We focus on Congress vote share as our primary outcome; however, we report results related to the likelihood of a Congress win in Appendix E.2, Table E.4 and Appendix E.1, Table E.2. We further collect polling station-level data from the first election after the yatra to examine the spatial limits of leader-driven grassroots campaigns.

5.1 State Elections

We estimate the effect of the yatra on state legislative assembly elections, concentrating on five states (Karnataka, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh) where the yatra traversed and elections were held. We report the effect of the yatra on Congress vote share in Table 1. In Model 1, which focuses on all five states, the yatra increased the INC’s vote share by 3.39 percentage points, equivalent to an increase of approximately one-fifth of a standard deviation. When disaggregating the analysis by the timing of elections, we find that the effect is concentrated in races held approximately seven months after the yatra passed through the state, namely, the Karnataka elections. By the time of the electoral races, 11 months or more after the election (Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Telangana, and

Andhra Pradesh elections), the estimated effects on Congress’s vote share are small and statistically insignificant. In Karnataka, constituencies traversed by the yatra experienced a 4.49 percentage point increase in INC vote share—representing a 12% gain relative to the state’s average Congress vote share. The event study in Figure 3 confirms the parallel trends assumption for the positive and statistically significant effects observed in elections held seven months after the yatra.

In Table E.1 in Appendix E.1, we examine how the distance to the yatra (measured from the distance of the route to the centroid of a constituency) affects Congress’s vote in state elections. The approach is preferable to comparing yatra constituencies to nearby constituencies since constituency sizes vary so some nearby constituencies would be more likely have exposure than other. Similar to the results in Table 1, we observe an aggregate effect for all state elections, primarily driven by Karnataka. In Karnataka, the result suggests that a greater distance from the yatra route is associated with a lower Congress vote share. It is worth noting that in the 2023 Karnataka elections, the BJP was viewed as corrupt and ineffective, facing an uphill battle which may have set the context for Congress to see vote share improvements. However, in this context, where the BJP faced statewide anti-incumbency, Congress’s vote share increased more in constituencies directly exposed to the yatra than in comparable constituencies that were not exposed.

Table 1: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in State Elections

	DV: Congress Vote Share			
	all state elections	elections 7 months since yatra	elections 11-13 months since yatra	elections 19 months since yatra
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
BJY _i x Post _t	3.39*** (1.26)	4.49** (2.05)	-0.11 (1.44)	0.20 (0.89)
Observations	3747	891	2160	696
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
AC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (AC)	948	224	549	175
Mean of DV	32.29	38.38	36.57	11.24

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level.

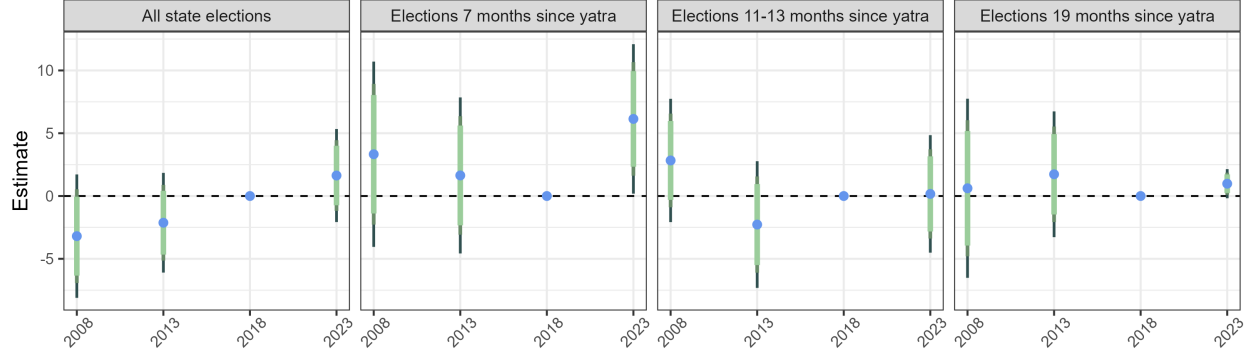


Figure 3: Effect on INC Vote Share in State Elections: Event Study

Notes: Election years are standardized to 2008, 2013, 2018, and 2024 (actual AP elections were in 2009, 2013, 2019, and 2024). Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level. 90%, 95%, and 99% confidence intervals are shown.

5.2 National Elections

Next, we examine the effect of the yatra on Congress's vote share in national elections, focusing on different subsets of constituencies. Our results from the state elections reveal that as time passes, there may be no positive effect. The national elections were held 15 to 19 months after the yatra crossed a state, suggesting that it is unlikely that we will observe significant positive impacts of the yatra on Congress's vote share. However, some constituencies may exhibit lingering effects more than a year after the yatra.

In Table 2, we show the effect of the yatra on Congress's vote share in national elections. In Model 1, focusing on all assembly constituencies, we find a small and statistically insignificant effect of the yatra on Congress vote share. One challenge in examining Congress's vote share in national elections is the variation in alliance formations over time. For example, in Uttar Pradesh, the Samajwadi Party contested separately from Congress in 2019, but in 2024, they formed a joint front as part of the INDIA alliance. To account for this, in Model 2, we restrict the sample to constituencies where Congress contested in all four elections. We again find no significant effect of the yatra on the INC vote share. These findings are consistent with the expectation that the yatra's effect would diminish over time.

In 2024, the INDIA alliance between Congress and other prominent regional parties led to various seat-sharing agreements across states. In some states, Congress was the leading alliance party, contesting the majority of the seats against the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance. These states would be more likely to have a longer-term effect of the yatra, given Congress's central role in national politics there. In Models 3 and 4, we focus on states where Congress was the main alliance party against the BJP.⁷ In these states, we find that the

⁷We measure this by focusing on states where the INC contested in more than 80% of the constituencies

yatra increased Congress's vote share by 2.30 to 3.01 percentage points. The event study in Figure 5 supports the parallel trends assumption, reinforcing the credibility of the positive and statistically significant effects observed in the model focused on Congress-led states measured in 2024. In Appendix E.2 we report several robustness checks. We present results at the parliamentary constituency level, which are in the same direction but are statistically insignificant, likely due to the broader treatment definition. We also estimate the same model using distance to the yatra as the treatment, which shows the same substantive patterns as we find in Table 2.

Table 2: Effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections

	DV: Congress Vote Share			
	All States	Congress Always Contest(2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2024)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
BJY $i \times \text{Post}_t$	0.29 (0.83)	0.53 (0.83)	2.13** (0.97)	2.30** (0.94)
Observations	12328	8608	9421	7622
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
AC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (AC)	3743	2157	2576	1973
Mean of DV	30.66	34.33	31.61	34.04

Notes: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level.

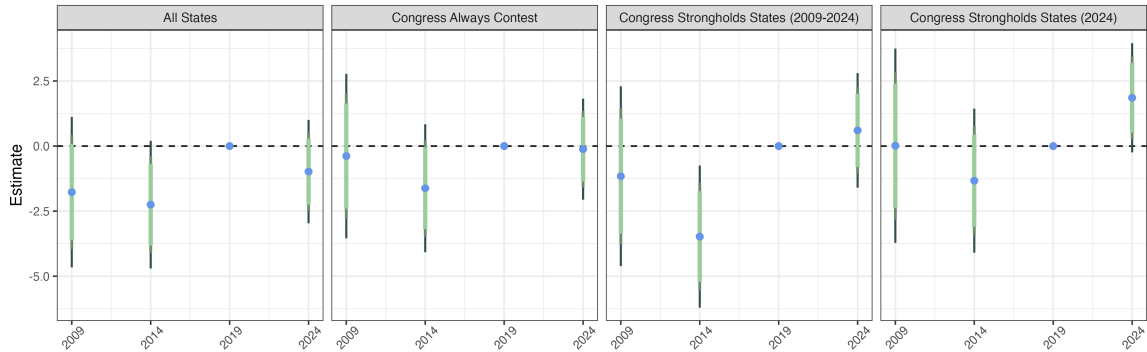


Figure 4: Event Study for 2024 National Election

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level. 90%, 95%, and 99% confidence intervals are shown.

Overall, the effect of the yatra dissipated by the time of the national elections. However, there is still an observable effect in places where Congress was the key opposition party against the BJP. The yatra platformed Congress leaders and the Congress party, making its impact most likely in places where the Congress party, not other opposition parties, matters. The impact of the leader-driven grassroots campaign appears limited to the party that mobilized voters, with little spillover to allied parties.

for all four elections in Model 3 and more than 80% of the constituencies for only the 2024 elections in Model 4.

5.2.1 Robustness: Difference-in-Differences with Matched Sample

As shown in Table D.2 in Appendix D, treated and control assembly constituencies differ in terms of the INC presence and electoral success. Although our difference-in-differences empirical strategy (Equation 1) accounts for time-invariant differences in covariates between treated and control units, we further strengthen our identification by performing a 1:1 nearest-neighbor matching (one matched control unit for each treated unit). To further strengthen the causal interpretation of our results, we then re-estimate the difference-in-differences specification using the matched sample for our national-level results.

Table 3 reports covariate balance before and after propensity score matching. The standardized mean differences across all covariates decline substantially after matching, with nearly all values falling well below the conventional threshold of 0.1, indicating that the treated and control groups are now highly comparable. Following Rosenbaum and Rubin (1983); Heckman, Ichimura and Todd (1998), these results suggest that the matching procedure effectively removed pre-treatment differences between treated and control constituencies. We provide further diagnostics in the Appendix H.

Table 3: Covariate Balance Before and After Matching

Variable	Before Matching			After Matching		
	Treated	Control	Std. Diff.	Treated	Control	Std. Diff.
Propensity Score	0.083	0.051	0.760	0.082	0.082	0.001
Effective Number of Parties	2.446	2.375	0.154	2.443	2.445	-0.003
Share of GEN Constituency	0.797	0.707	0.223	0.796	0.777	0.047
Share of SC Constituency	0.156	0.150	0.016	0.156	0.161	-0.013
Share of ST Constituency	0.047	0.143	-0.452	0.047	0.062	-0.067
INC Vote Share	31.983	21.455	0.634	31.953	33.337	-0.083
INC Deposit Lost	0.175	0.450	-0.726	0.175	0.166	0.025
INC Did Not Contest	0.094	0.196	-0.347	0.095	0.043	0.178
Total Electors in AC	228030	223613	0.070	226456	229911	-0.054
Voter Turnout	68.385	69.576	-0.140	68.474	69.361	-0.104

Table 4 presents the results from the matched difference-in-differences specification and Figure 5 shows the event study. Across all model specifications, we continue to find a positive and statistically significant effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress vote share in national elections. In the full sample (Model 1) and constituencies where Congress contested in all four elections (Model 2), yatra constituencies experienced a 2.42-2.48 percentage point higher Congress vote share relative to matched comparable non-yatra constituencies. The magnitude of the estimated effect increases in states where Congress has historically been the principal opposition to the BJP. Specifically, in states where the INC contested more than 80% of the constituencies across all four elections (Model 3), the yatra increased Congress's

vote share by 3.65 percentage points. The effect remains positive and statistically significant at 3.01 percentage points when focusing on states where the INC was the main alliance partner only in 2024 (Model 4). Taken together, these results are consistent with our main estimates, indicating that the positive electoral impact of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress performance is not driven by pre-existing constituency characteristics.

Table 4: Effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections

	DV: Congress Vote Share			
	All States	Congress Always Contest(2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2024)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
BJY _i x Post _t	2.48** (1.16)	2.42** (1.17)	3.65** (1.46)	3.01** (1.43)
Observations	1459	1183	1047	924
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
AC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (AC)	405	296	277	236
Mean of DV	36.4	37.88	35.85	36.65

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level.

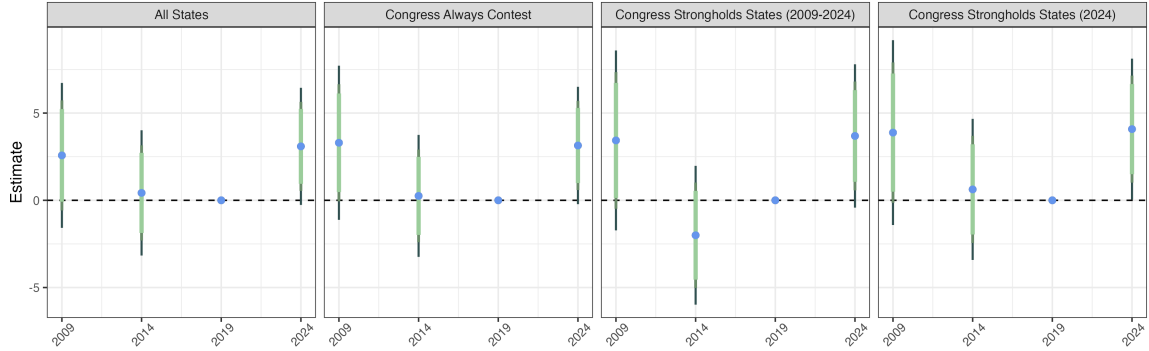


Figure 5: Event Study for 2024 National Election (Matched DID)

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the assembly constituency level. 90%, 95%, and 99% confidence intervals are shown.

5.3 Detailed Study of the Karnataka State Elections

The analysis so far treats an assembly constituency as treated if the yatra crossed it and the supplementary analysis examines the distance from the yatra to the constituency centroid. However, with a constituency average size of 900 sq km and 200,000 voters, this broad definition of treatment may underestimate the yatra's effect. To generate a precise estimate of the yatra's effect, we move to the micro-level and focus on Karnataka, the first state to hold an election after the yatra.

We scrape and geo-locate polling-station-level election results for Karnataka in 2018 and 2023. At this level, treatment is defined as spatial proximity to the yatra route, which serves

as a proxy for direct exposure to the march rather than indirect awareness through media or party messaging. Because polling station boundaries and identifiers change across elections, we are unable to construct a multi-period pre-treatment event study at the polling station level. The analysis, therefore, compares two elections and should be interpreted as difference-in-differences with limited pre-trend diagnostics. To match polling station overtime, we match them in two ways: first, by exact number match, which is less conservative and may include renumbered stations (“Number-Matched Sample”), and second, by exact station name match, which is more conservative (“Exact Name-Matched Sample”). Details are in Appendix F.

With these two samples, we estimate several two-period difference-in-differences models to examine how being proximate to the yatra route impacted Congress’s vote share. The results are shown in Table 5. In Models 1 and 4, we define a polling station as treated if the yatra crossed through an assembly constituency in which the station is located.⁸ We find that there is an 8.76-9.20 percentage point increase in Congress vote share in polling stations in assembly constituencies that the yatra crossed, reflecting about a 20% increase from the mean Congress vote share across both elections in Karnataka. These results are similar but slightly larger in magnitude when we define treatment based on if the route crossed the area covered by the polling station (Models 2 and 5).⁹ Finally, in Models 3 and 6, we use a continuous treatment of the log distance to the yatra route to examine how moving away from the yatra route impacted Congress’s vote share. To understand this effect, consider two polling stations: one 10 km from the yatra route and another 100 km away. The station farther away would likely have a Congress vote share about 6.22 percentage points lower than the closer one. These results show larger effects than previous aggregate results, likely due to a more precise measure of yatra exposure and the focus on the first state that held elections after the yatra.

As a robustness test, we apply a method developed by (Butts 2023), which does not assume that the effect changes linearly as we move away from the yatra route. The method divides the sample into distance quantiles and the effect is then estimated non-parametrically within each bin by comparing units before and after treatment. The estimated effect from the most distant bin is subtracted from the others to normalize the results.

⁸The percent of treated polling stations is 8.5% in the Number-Matched Sample and 7.7% in the Exact Name-Matched Sample.

⁹The percent of treated polling stations is 0.082% in the Number-Matched Sample and 0.78% in the Exact Name-Matched Sample.

Table 5: Effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections

	DV: Congress Vote Share					
	Number-Matched Sample			Exact Name-Matched Sample		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
$BJY(AC)_i \times Post_t$	9.20*** (2.57)			8.76*** (2.28)		
$BJY(PS)_i \times Post_t$		10.59*** (1.02)			13.63*** (1.65)	
$Log(Dist\ to\ BGY)_i \times Post_t$			-2.44*** (0.10)			-2.77*** (0.13)
Treatment Definition	Route Crosses AC	Route Crosses PS	Distance to Route	Route Crosses AC	Route Crosses PS	Distance to Route
Observations	105796	105796	105796	57606	57606	57606
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Polling Station FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (AC)	224	57300	57300	205	34467	34467
Mean of DV	41.1	41.1	41.1	41.25	41.25	41.25

Notes: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Treatment is defined at the assembly constituency (AC) level in Columns 1 and 4 (SEs clustered at AC level), at the polling station (PS) level in Columns 2 and 5 (clustered at PS level), and as a continuous measure (log distance to the yatra) in Columns 3 and 6 (also clustered at PS level).

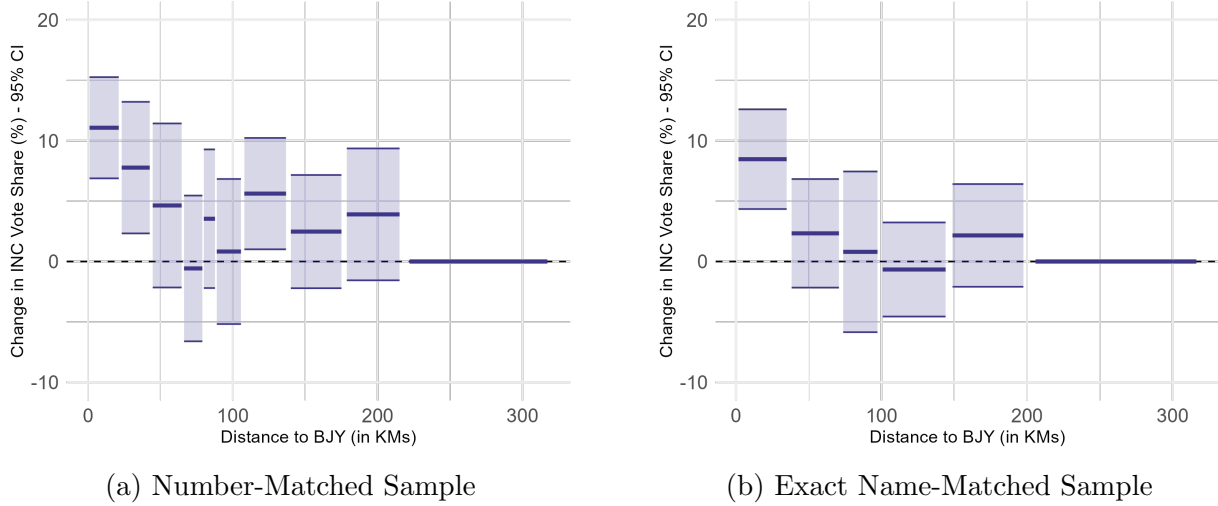


Figure 6: The effect of distance on INC vote share

The results from this analysis are visualized in Figure 6. The figure reveals that the positive effects of the yatra on the INC vote share are concentrated within approximately 50 kilometers of the yatra route. We interpret this finding as suggesting that the effect of the yatra is likely to come from some direct interaction with the march. Across all of our analysis, our design assumes that there is something critical about experiencing the yatra, beyond just hearing about it more broadly. If we believe that news about the yatra reached the country as a whole, then each design estimates the impact of a more direct experience with the yatra.

6 How Exposure to Leader-Driven Grassroots Campaigns Can Help the Opposition

Our results demonstrate that grassroots campaigns by Rahul Gandhi, through the BJJ increased the INC’s vote share in a limited way, ultimately mattering for elections that were temporally proximate, geographically close to the yatra route, and for the party organizing the yatra itself. Our theoretical argument highlights that leader-driven grassroots campaigns may work for opposition parties facing populists because they address several key challenges they experience. To understand how this works for the yatra, we present evidence from interviews with twenty Congress party leaders and workers, civil society organizations, and voters, primarily in Karnataka, seven months after the election, alongside additional quantitative analysis. We discuss the interview methodology and limitations in Appendix J. The evidence highlights that leader-driven grassroots campaigns allow the opposition to counter the narrative of being elite, reach voters in a pro-incumbent environment, and improve perceptions of their electoral viability.

6.1 Countering the Elite Narrative

The yatra helped Congress shed its elite image. During Modi’s rise, the party used populist rhetoric to portray Congress as elite, while the BJP was portrayed as connected with the masses (Varshney, Ayyangar and Swaminathan 2021; Leidig and Mudde 2023; Naseemullah and Chhibber 2024). Modi’s emphasis on his humble origins contrasted with the opposition’s dynastic politics. In interviews, voters suggested that the yatra played a key role in challenging the narrative of Gandhi and the Congress as elite. One voter described his effort to connect: “Rahul Gandhi walked and listened to our problems.”¹⁰ Other voters highlighted that it was impactful to “see a party leader walking and doing this hardship”¹¹ and that “everyday when Rahul Gandhi walked people were thinking whether he would have the capacity to do the entire thing and he then he did.”¹² One Congress worker said that “the yatra showed people that [he] was not just inheriting power.” Politicians regularly criticized Gandhi as an ineffective leader and often derided as “Pappu.” In places that experienced the yatra, voters claimed that “fewer people would refer to Rahul Gandhi as Pappu” stating that they “could no longer attack him like that after he walked across the entire country to meet them.”¹³

¹⁰ Author interview with voter. January 8, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

¹¹ Author interview with voter. January 8, 2024. Bangalore Urban District

¹² Author interview with voter. January 9, 2024. Mandya District

¹³ Author interview with Congress team member. January 10, 2024. Mysore District.

6.2 Reaching Voters in a Pro-Incumbent Environment

The government’s crackdown on independent news and journalists, along with efforts to centralize ownership of media companies, created an environment where the opposition would struggle to break through (Bhat 2023; Tudor 2023). The yatra provided an opportunity to gain coverage and engage voters directly, even in the pro-incumbent environment. Party workers highlighted that a diverse set of media covered Congress during the yatra. One member of the Congress team explained that “the alternative media started covering the yatra because the mainstream media was not covering it as well” and this “created a buzz” in which “people viewed Congress as different than before.”¹⁴ The spectacle of the yatra further boosted voters’ interest, prompting many to seek out more information.

One observable implication of this would be increased political interest in topics related to the yatra. We test this using data from Google Trends, which researchers use to capture average internet search patterns among defined populations over time and space (Dancy and Fariss 2024). We examine the dynamic treatment effect of the yatra entering a state on political interest in a search topic using an event study for staggered adoption of the treatment (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021). Figure 7 reports how searches related to Bharat Jodo Yatra, Rahul Gandhi, Indian National Congress, Narendra Modi, and Bharatiya Janata Party changed in the days leading up to and after the entry of the yatra into the particular state (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021). In Appendix G we describe the data collection process, analysis choices, and robustness to alternative models.

We observed a large increase in search interest for the Bharat Jodo Yatra and Rahul Gandhi, and a smaller increase for the Indian National Congress in the days following the yatra’s entry. For each of these terms, interest levels return to pre-yatra baselines approximately 15–20 days after the yatra. We find no impact of the yatra on political interest in Narendra Modi or the BJP. We interpret these findings as evidence that the yatra generated increased demand for information about the movement, the leader, and the party, despite the challenges traditionally faced by the opposition in a pro-incumbent media environment.

¹⁴Author interview with Congress team member. January 7, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

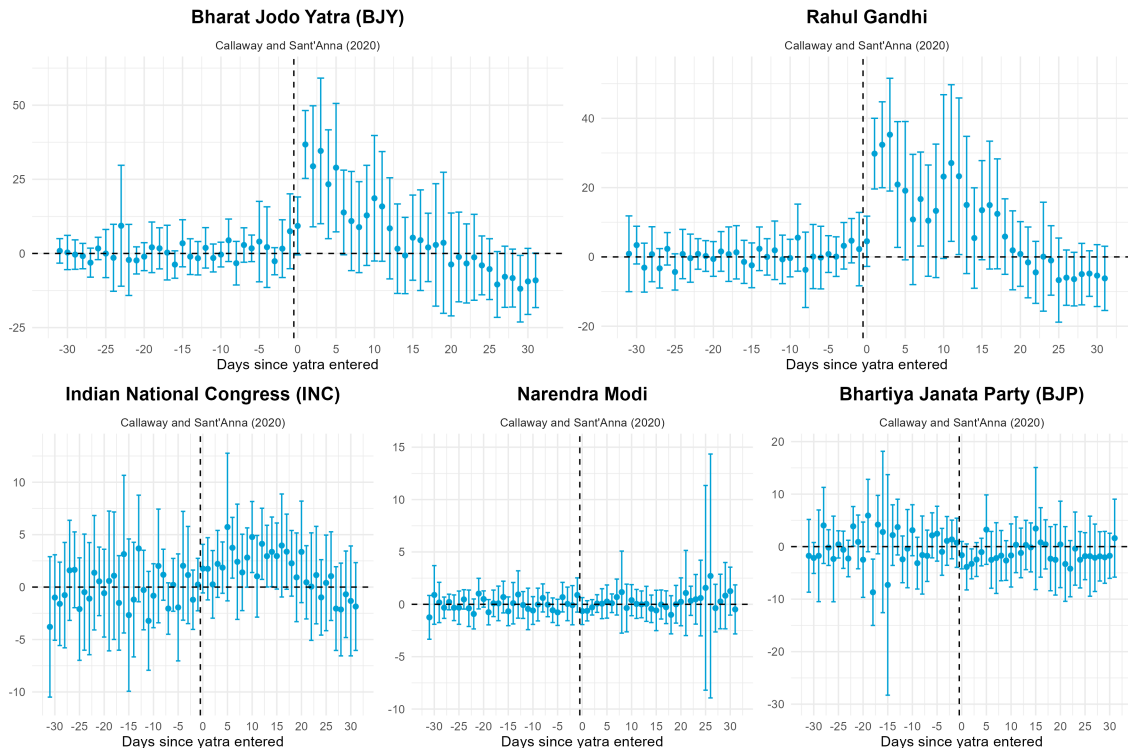


Figure 7: Impacts of BJY on Google Search Outcomes

6.3 Improving Perceptions of Viability

The yatra improved Congress’s perception of viability, despite the tilt in the electoral playing field. Increasing deference of the Election Commission to the executive (Vaishnav 2024a), reduced transparency in election financing through the use of electoral bonds (Vaishnav 2024b), and legal troubles for regional opposition leaders contributed to voter perceptions that incumbent victory was inevitable and opposition viability was low.

Interviews with voters in areas that experienced the yatra revealed how it changed the discourse around Congress, making the party appear more viable. One voter described how on a “mass level the impression of the party went up” and that “people seemed more likely to accept the Congress.”¹⁵ This perception was shared by Congress party workers as well, a local Congress party worker in Mandya district, Karnataka, where the yatra passed, described how party membership increased: “after the yatra the members doubled¹⁶, especially we had many youth joining the party.”¹⁷

Improved perceptions of viability were also linked to the view that the yatra presented

¹⁵Author interview with Congress team member. January 9, 2024. Mandya District.

¹⁶We were unable to verify this but it reflects a perception that party elites noticed an increase in membership

¹⁷Author interview with Congress team member. January 9, 2024. Mandya District

the Congress party as a united front against the incumbent. For example, in Karnataka, Congress Party workers highlighted how two senior Congress leaders representing different factions within the party walked together hand-in-hand with Rahul Gandhi during the yatra, which “neutralized allegations of infighting in the Congress.”¹⁸ In fact, a large poster of Rahul Gandhi walking hand in hand with these leaders was still displayed outside the Congress office building 15 months after the yatra had left Karnataka. The yatra showed that the party was united and internal factions would not limit its viability, especially considering the history of factional politics in the Congress (Brass 1965; Kochanek 1968).

By helping to build party organization in areas where the yatra passed, it also increased Congress’s visibility and viability. One member of Gandhi’s team highlighted that the yatra provided party workers with an opportunity to “interact with Rahul Gandhi and get pictures with him” contributing to “cadre-based enthusiasm” where “the workers felt like this was the moment for the party.”¹⁹ This reinvigorated party organization could be expected to contribute to greater mobilization. One observable implication is an increase in election activity in yatra constituencies in the lead-up to the 2024 elections.

Using data on campaign rallies by the BJP (led by Narendra Modi or Home Minister Amit Shah) and the INC (led by Rahul Gandhi or his sister Priyanka Gandhi), we examine whether yatra constituencies hosted more INC rallies.²⁰ The data on rallies during the 2024 elections are at the parliamentary constituency level, so we examine whether the share of rallies differs across yatra and non-yatra PCs. Because constituencies with the yatra are different from those without, we match each yatra PC to a non-yatra PC that is similar on pre-treatment covariates using propensity score matching described in Appendix H.4. Using this matched sample, Figure 8 shows that BGY constituencies had double the share of Congress rallies (35%) compared to matched non-BGY constituencies (17%) ahead of the 2024 national elections (this difference is significant, $p = 0.02$). There is no significant difference for the BJP. While it is possible that yatra constituencies were electorally strategic for Congress, leading both to their selection for the yatra and the subsequent rallies, by focusing on the matched sample, we alleviate such concerns. In the matched sample, we compare constituencies that are similar in 2019 INC performance and other characteristics, with the key remaining difference being whether or not the yatra passed through it. As such, there is some evidence that the organizational capacity built during the yatra helped facilitate future mobilization even when accounting for past INC performance.

¹⁸ Author interview with Congress team member. January 8, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

¹⁹ Author interview with Congress team member. January 7, 2024. Bangalore Urban District.

²⁰ The location of rallies was collected by a researcher in India and is described in the [Times of India](#).

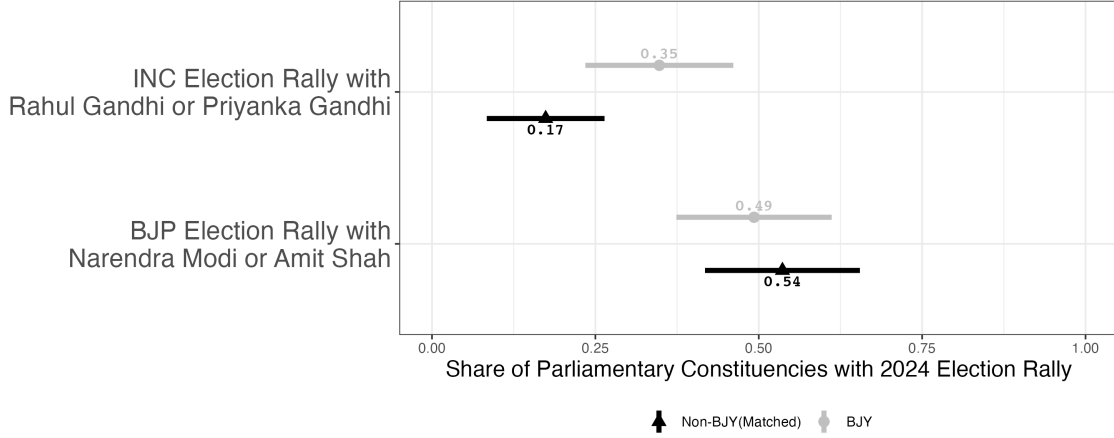


Figure 8: BJP and Congress Election Campaign Rallies in BJY and matched non-BJY Constituencies

7 How Participation in Leader-Driven Grassroots Campaigns Impacts Voters

We now examine the individual-level dynamics of leader-driven grassroots campaigns through an original telephone survey of 3,510 citizens in Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh in January 2024, over a year after the yatra. We stratified the sample on places that the yatra did and did not cross, allowing us to obtain enough respondents who could have participated directly in the yatra. We use post-stratification weights provided by the public opinion survey firm to achieve representativeness on age, gender, education, income, social group, and rurality for each state in all of our analyses. In Appendix I we provide details on the survey protocol, sample, and questionnaire.

7.1 Participants of the Yatra

In our survey, 24% of respondents reported participating in the yatra in some way (e.g., attending an event or side meeting, walking with the march). Table 9 shows the demographic and political characteristics of yatra participants compared to non-participants. We do not observe significant differences in gender, age, income, and education between yatra participants and non-participants. This suggests that leader-driven grassroots campaigns are not confined to particular voter demographics but rather have a broad-ranging appeal. We do, however, find that rural respondents made up a greater share of yatra participants, likely due to the higher coverage of rural areas and the spectacle of a yatra in these places. In terms of social groups, yatra participants were slightly more likely to include individuals

from Scheduled Castes and Tribes; however, there were no significant differences for other social groups.

Looking at the party that voters reported supporting in 2019, which they were asked about earlier in the survey, we can understand the political reach of the yatra. Congress voters made up a larger share of yatra participants (55%) than non-participants (28%), while BJP voters made up a lower share of yatra participants (40%) than non-participants (60%). Notably, 17% of respondents who reported voting for the BJP in 2019 also participated in the yatra, suggesting that leader-driven campaigns can extend beyond core supporters to engage potential swing voters. At the same time, among Congress supporters, 39% participated in the yatra. This engagement across both groups suggests that leader-driven grassroots campaigns can assist opposition parties in reaching both core and swing voters (Cox and McCubbins 1986; Dixit and Londregan 1996).

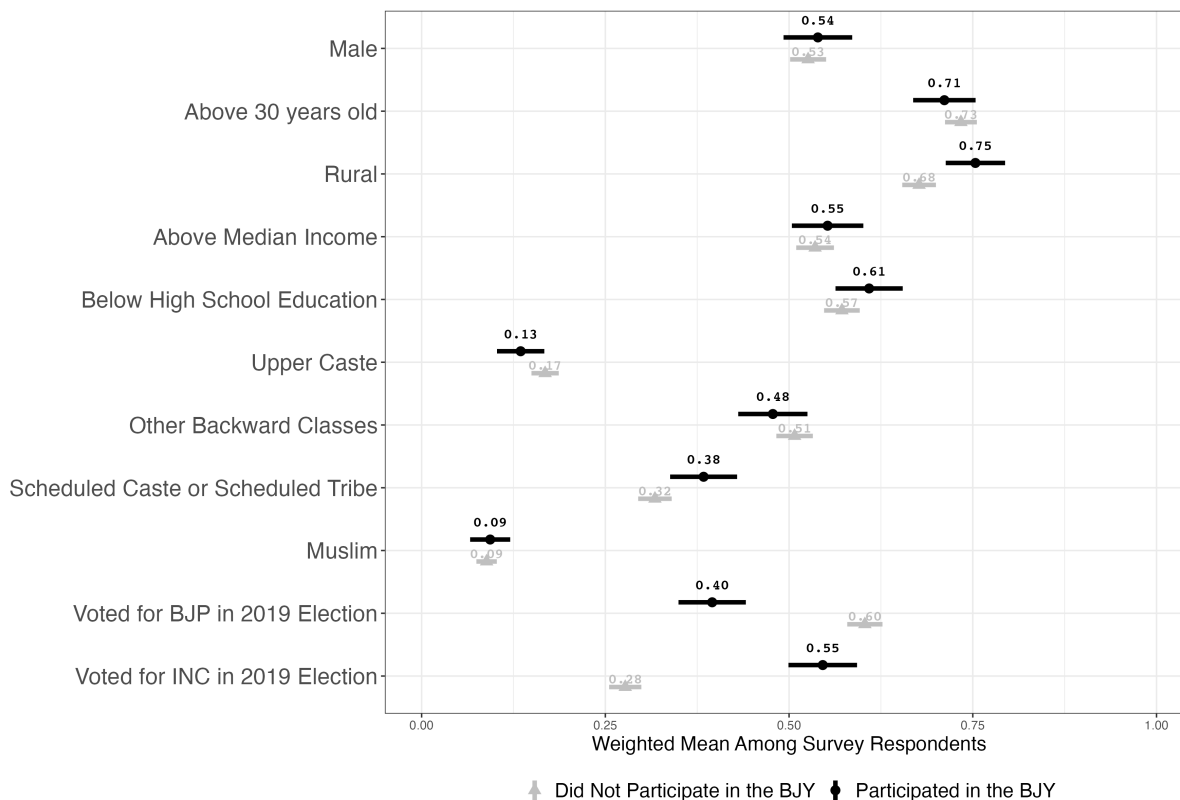


Figure 9: Demographic Characteristics of Yatra Participants

7.2 The Impact of Yatra Participation

Through a cross-sectional analysis of the survey, we examine how participation in the yatra is associated with differences in individual perceptions, political engagement, and voting

behavior. More details on the survey questions are included in Appendix I. In Figure I.4, we present the effects for each outcome variable across four samples of the survey data. First, across the full sample of all respondents, we find that participation in the yatra was associated with improved perceptions of Congress and Rahul Gandhi, increased engagement with the INC, and discourse about Rahul Gandhi. We find small and insignificant associations between yatra participation on similar outcomes related to the BJP. In terms of voting, yatra participants are more likely to report having voted for the INC in the 2023 state elections, less likely to report having voted for the BJP in both elections, and more likely to vote for the Congress today. We find consistent patterns among respondents who voted for the BJP in 2019 and those who voted for Congress in 2019. Among INC voters, the effect sizes are positive but smaller in magnitude, likely because these voters already held favorable views of the party and were predisposed to support it.

To further isolate the relationship between direct participation and longer-term impacts, we restrict the sample to only those respondents in assembly constituencies through which the yatra passed and compare participants with non-participants. The effects remain strong and statistically significant, suggesting that participation itself, rather than merely being in a yatra-visited area, drives longer-term change in attitudes and behavior. This is consistent with earlier findings from polling station-level data, where more granular definitions of “treatment” that may capture participation yielded stronger effects than broader constituency-level classifications. In Appendix I, we demonstrate the robustness of these results.

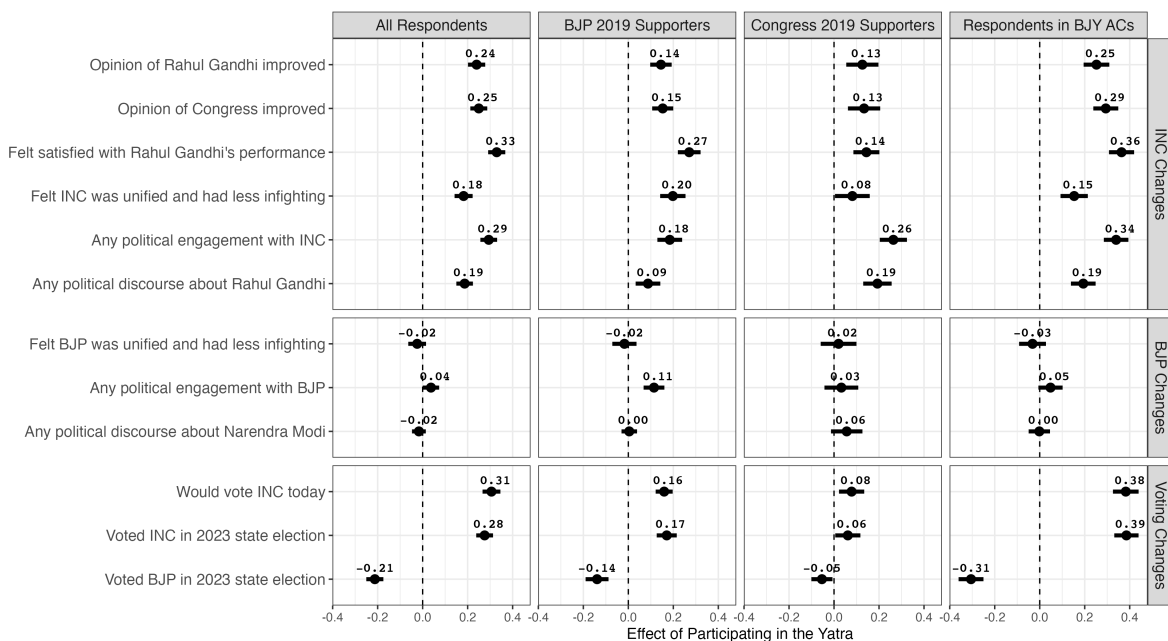


Figure 10: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes

Together, the descriptive results suggest that participation in the yatra is not demographically constrained. Moreover, participation in the BJY had lasting impacts on voter perceptions, engagement, and vote choice, highlighting the crucial role of direct connections with leader-driven campaigns.

8 Conclusion

The most decisive way to defeat a populist incumbent is at the ballot box. However, opposition political parties face an uphill battle in doing so. Populists frame the opposition as out of touch with voters, shape the environment to make it difficult for the opposition to break through to voters, and influence the electoral space to present the opposition as nonviable given the populists' dominance. In the face of these challenges, we argue that the opposition can adopt leader-driven grassroots campaigns to make electoral inroads against a populist at the ballot box.

Opposition parties across contexts have taken this strategy in response to populists, especially those engaging in democratic erosion. In 2017, in Turkey, Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu led the Justice March against backsliding by the Erdoğan regime. In 2020, in Tanzania, Freeman Mbowe led a walking rally for the Chadema party against the ruling CCM party. In 2025, in Hungary, Peter Magyar led the One Million Steps for Peace and National Unity march in response to democratic backsliding by Orbán. And while political commentators often suggest that these efforts could have an impact on the opposition's prospects, a comprehensive examination of this form of party-voter interaction is lacking.

We examine the impact of these leader-driven grassroots campaigns by focusing on Congress Party Leader Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra. We find that the yatra increased Congress's vote share, but these effects were concentrated in elections temporally proximate to the yatra, in places spatially nearby to the yatra route, and for the party that was at the center of the yatra. Interviews and additional descriptive analysis reveal that the campaign countered the narrative of Congress as an elite party, allowed the opposition to break through in a pro-incumbent environment, and improved perceptions of the party's viability. Individual-level survey evidence shows that participating in the yatra was associated with improved perceptions and engagement with the opposition one year later, highlighting that interacting with the leader-driven grassroots campaign was crucial to its impact.

The findings should also be interpreted in the context of the Congress Party's electoral performance in the 2024 general elections. The election marked the first time in 10 years that the ruling BJP did not win an outright majority without the support of its alliance partners. The Congress party performed better than expected for a range of reasons, such as

their ability to form a wide-ranging alliance with regional parties, their new ideological pitch with a bend toward justice and democratic legitimacy, their management of the internal party organization and caste-based distribution of nominations, and their effective populist appeals to the middle class (Verma and Pratikshit 2024; Chhibber 2024; Aiyar and Sircar 2025; Verniers 2025). This paper demonstrates that the Bharat Jodo Yatra also played a unique role in improving Congress’s electoral performance in the general elections in states where Congress was the key party in the INDIA alliance.

Zooming out from India, the findings suggest that leader-driven campaigns can help the opposition in challenging a populist incumbent electorally. However, these campaigns are not a panacea. Their effectiveness is both geographically and temporally constrained, and they are less impactful in areas where the campaigning party is not the primary opposition face. Importantly, increasing the frequency or expanding the reach of such campaigns does not necessarily enhance their effectiveness. Instead, their influence may lie partly in their atypicality, costliness, and the spectacle they create for the opposition. Still, these campaigns have a lasting influence on voters who engage directly with them. As opposition parties use leader-driven grassroots campaigns, they can raise their impact by mobilizing voters to participate in them.

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Online Appendix for *The Promise and Limits of Leader-Driven Grassroots Campaigns*

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A Defining Leader Driven Grassroots Campaigns

We identify four key components of a party-voter event that define what type of event it is. The components are: the key party actor, the voter audience, the pitch, and the typicality. The key party actor can be the leader, the candidate(s), or the party organization (i.e., party position-holders, the rank-and-file). The voter audience can be all citizens or party supporters. The pitch is based on both what the party says during the interaction with the voter and the timing of it. The pitch can be electoral (i.e., occurring during an election campaign or concerning why a citizen should vote for the party) or non-electoral (i.e., happening outside of an electoral campaign or concerning a broader ideological message). The event’s typicality is typical when the event is very common and not out of the ordinary or atypical when it is rare and viewed as more extraordinary. Table A.1 shows how leader-driven grassroots campaigns compare on these dimensions to three other party-voter events: rallies, canvassing, and town halls.

Table A.1: Typology of Party-Voter Events

	Leader-Driven Grassroots Campaigns	Rallies	Canvassing	Town Halls
Key Party Actor	Party Leader	Party Leader or Candidates	Party Organization	Candidates
Voter Audience	All citizens	Supporters	All citizens	Supporters
Pitch	Non-Electoral	Electoral	Electoral or Non-electoral	Electoral or Non-Electoral
Typicality	Atypical	Typical	Typical	Typical
Indian Examples	Bharat Jodo Yatra	Modi rally	Door-to-door campaign	Nukkad Sabhas
General Examples	Justice March (Turkey) One Million Steps (Hungary)	Trump rallies ¹ Hitler rallies ²	François Hollande’s door-to-door campaign ³	Deliberation town halls in Benin ⁴

¹ See Snyder and Yousaf (2020).

² See Selb and Munzert (2018).

³ See Pons (2018).

⁴ See Wantchekon and Guardado (2024).

B Context: Congress Decline and the Rise of the BJP

The Indian National Congress was founded in 1885 with the goal of demanding representation in the government for educated Indians (Kumar 2024). The initial decades of the Congress focused on an “intellectual agitation” to articulate its demands and goals (Kothari 1964). By the 1920s and 1930s, the party had transformed into “a mass movement with depth and traditions,” a shift largely driven by Gandhi’s grassroots mobilization efforts that united citizens across ethnic and regional lines (Kothari 1964; Kumar 2024; Bhavnani and Jha 2014).

Scholars have long characterized India’s party system around the electoral centrality of the Congress Party since Independence (Yadav 1999; Vaishnav and Hinton 2019). In

the two decades following 1947, Congress functioned as a “party of consensus,” despite its dependence on particular social coalitions across states (Kothari 1964; Weiner 1967). A fragmented opposition enabled Congress to dominate both national and state elections during this period (Vaishnav and Hinton 2019; Yadav 1999). The Congress party’s primary competition was not from the opposition parties but from factions within the party itself (Brass 1965; Kochanek 1968), which the party was able to manage well in this period (Weiner 1967; Kothari 1964).

From 1967-1989, the INC began to lose out at the state level but retained dominance nationally, even recovering after its defeat following Indira Gandhi’s moment of authoritarianism during the Emergency (Yadav 1999). During this phase, the Congress Party increasingly came to depend on its control over state institutions to distribute patronage, marking a departure from its earlier identity as a mass movement (Wilkinson 2007; Chhibber 2001). For example, Chhibber (2001) notes how Congress party workers became attuned to the role of resources in mobilizing votes, making their motivations for joining the party more reflective of self-interest than of influencing policy. Wilkinson (2007) notes that as competition intensified, clientelism became both more extensive and more systematic.

Between 1989 and 2014, the rise of caste-based, religious, and class mobilization disrupted Congress’s status as “the single pole around which politics revolved” (Vaishnav and Hinton 2019) and prominent regional parties gained more power (Ziegfeld 2016). A confluence of factors contributed to Congress decline: ideological incoherence (Chhibber and Verma 2018; Hasan 2022), weakened organizational structure (Kothari 1964; Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019; Hasan 2012), persistent intra-party factionalism (Brass 1965), rising opposition coordination (Tudor and Ziegfeld 2019), sociopolitical shifts induced by the Green Revolution (Dasgupta 2018), and the rise of new political identities (Jaffrelot and Kumar 2012). In 2014 and 2019, Congress suffered two consecutive major losses to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at the national level, ushering in the fourth party system with the BJP at the center of politics (Vaishnav and Hinton 2019; Jaffrelot and Verniers 2020).

C Data

C.1 Bharat Jodo Yatra Route

The Indian National Congress formally announced the Bharat Jodo Yatra on August 23, 2023. The official social media account (Facebook and X/Twitter) of Bharat Jodo Yatra released a schedule of daily on-foot journeys by Rahul Gandhi. We manually mapped this daily schedule from September 7, 2022, to January 30, 2023, every day. The Yatra covered

approximately 20 kilometers per day, with five to six designated stops each day. Because the yatra followed major highways, we connected these stops to construct a continuous route of over 4,000 kilometers, representing the Bharat Jodo Yatra. To ensure accuracy, we triangulated this route using three sources: contemporaneous newspaper reports, official social media feeds from the Congress party, and the live stream of the Yatra on YouTube, to account for any changes based on what social media had initially reported. We then validated our constructed route with the Indian National Congress. Figure 1 shows the BJY route. We use this route to identify “treated” electoral constituencies or places where the yatra crossed. We identify treatment at the assembly constituency (AC) level for our main analysis. This is the smallest, electorally meaningful unit for party-based electoral politics.²¹

C.2 Congress Electoral Performance

Our goal is to examine the impact of the yatra on Congress’ electoral performance in the subsequent state and national elections. At the national level, India uses a parliamentary system where voters elect members of the Lok Sabha, the lower house of Parliament, every 5 years. The party or coalition with the most seats forms the government and its leader becomes the Prime Minister. At the state level, the same electoral rules apply as voters elect Members of the Legislative Assembly with the majority party or coalition forming the state government and determining the Chief Minister. Both state and national elections use first-past-the-post electoral rules.

During the Bharat Jodo Yatra, Rahul Gandhi traveled across India between September 2022 and January 2023. In the period following the Yatra, state assembly elections were held in Karnataka (May 2023), Telangana, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh (all in December 2023), and Andhra Pradesh (May 2024). National parliamentary elections were conducted between April and June 2024.²²

State Assembly Election: The state assembly election results data for the states of Karnataka (2008, 2013, 2018), Madhya Pradesh (2008, 2013, 2018), Rajasthan (2008, 2013, 2018), Telangana (2009, 2014, 2018), and Andhra Pradesh (2009, 2014, 2019) are accessed from Trivedi Centre for Political Data (TCDP) (Agarwal et al. 2022).²³ For the most recent elections, Karnataka (2023), Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Telangana (2023), and Andhra

²¹Assembly constituencies are state-level electoral districts.

²²Between the yatra and the 2024 national elections, there were also state elections in Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, and Odisha; however, the yatra did not cross through any of these states.

²³For the state elections analysis, we standardize the years to 2008, 2013, 2018, and 2023. For the state of Telangana, the elections are 2009, 2014, 2018, and 2023. In all figures and tables, we will use 2008 for the 2009 election and 2013 for 2014 to keep the constituency with the other three states. For the state of Andhra Pradesh, the elections are 2009, 2014, 2019, 2024. In all figures and tables, we move these back by one year to allow for consistency in plotting.

Pradesh (2024), we scraped official results from the Election Commission of India. We restrict our analysis to elections held after 2008, as earlier results are not comparable due to changes in constituency boundaries following delimitation.

National Election: We collect national election results at the assembly constituency level.²⁴ There are 543 Parliamentary constituencies in India and within these there are about 5-9 assembly constituencies (AC). Using AC-level results for the national elections allows us more fine-grained data to understand the impact of the yatra. The AC level results for the Lok Sabha election give us votes polled by each candidate at the AC level from TCDP for the years 2009, 2014, and 2019 (Agarwal et al. 2022). For AC level results for 2024, we scrape, OCR and manually code the vote share for the Congress candidate for each assembly constituency from the election commission website for each state.²⁵ As with our state-level analysis, we limit our focus to elections conducted after 2008 due to changes in constituency boundaries following delimitation.

D Descriptive Details of Yatra and non-Yatra ACs

Table D.1 shows the differences between treated (BJY) and control constituencies on a range of outcomes related to the state election that happened before the yatra (the 2018 election for Karnataka, Telangana, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh and the 2019 election in Andhra Pradesh). Table D.2 shows the differences between treated (BJY) and control constituencies on a range of outcomes related to the 2019 national elections. These balance tables highlight that the yatra was more likely to occur in places where Congress had some footing in the prior election.

E Robustness and Additional Results

E.1 State Elections

In this section, we present a series of robustness and additional results related to the state election analysis. Table E.1 shows the effect of distance to the yatra on INC vote share in state elections. Table E.2 shows the effect of the yatra on Congress win in state elections.

²⁴We do not have AC level data for the following states: Jammu and Kashmir, Assam, Manipur, and Arunachal Pradesh.

²⁵We use the Form 20 polling station results to determine the vote share for Congress in each AC.

Table D.1: Balance Table: Treated and Control Constituencies in 2018 State Elections

Variable	BJY - Treated	Control	Difference	p-Value
Number of Candidates	13.333	13.431	-0.10	0.88
Number of Female Candidates	1.149	1.055	0.10	0.48
Share of INC Contesting	0.931	0.973	-0.04	0.13
Share of INC Winning	0.322	0.330	-0.01	0.87
INC Vote Share	35.286	31.585	3.70	0.05
Share of BJP Contesting	1.000	0.997	0.00	0.08
Share of BJP Winning	0.299	0.303	-0.00	0.93
BJP Vote Share	29.691	27.655	2.04	0.34
Turnout	74.70	76.64	-1.94	0.10
Share Reserved for SC/ST	0.276	0.273	0.00	0.96
Effective Number of Parties	2.578	2.690	-0.11	0.04
Distance to BJJ route (in KM)	8.115	196.937	-188.82	0.00

Note: Assembly Elections in the state of Karnataka, Telangana, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh took place in 2018 while in 2019 in Andhra Pradesh. P-values are from Welch two-sample t-tests.

E.2 National Elections

In this section, we present a series of robustness and additional results related to the national election analysis. Table E.3 shows the effect of the yatra on INC vote share in the national elections, measured at the PC-level. Table E.5 shows the effect of distance to the yatra on INC vote share in national elections measured at the PC-level while Table E.6 does so at the AC-level. Table E.4 shows the effect of the yatra on Congress win in national elections, measured at the PC-level.

We use two measures for if Congress was the main alliance party against the BJP. In those labeled as “Congress Stronghold States (2008-2024)” we measure this by focusing on states where the INC contested in more than 80% of the constituencies for all four elections. This results in the following 20 states: Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Odisha, Puducherry, Punjab, Rajasthan, Sikkim, Telangana, Tripura, and Uttarakhand. In those labeled as “Congress Stronghold States (2024)” we measure this by focusing on states where the INC contested in more than 80% of the constituencies for only the 2024 elections. This results in the following 18 states: Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Odisha, Puducherry, Punjab, Rajasthan, Sikkim, Telangana, and Uttarakhand.

Table D.2: Balance Table: Treated and Control Constituencies in 2019 General Elections

Variable	BJY - Treated	Control	Difference	p-value	Level
Share of INC Winning	0.307	0.138	0.17	0.00	AC
INC Vote Share	35.315	26.680	8.63	0.00	AC
Share of BJP Winning	0.448	0.514	-0.07	0.06	AC
BJP Vote Share	42.657	45.507	-2.85	0.07	AC
Effective Number of Parties	2.446	2.375	0.07	0.03	AC
Distance to BJY route (in KM)	6.552	558.846	-552.29	0.00	AC
Number of Candidates	17.224	15.337	1.89	0.00	PC
Number of Female Candidates	1.349	1.363	-0.01	0.69	PC
Share of INC Contesting	0.804	0.729	0.08	0.00	PC
Share of BJP Contesting	0.800	0.797	0.00	0.77	PC
Turnout	67.149	65.669	1.48	0.00	PC
Share Reserved for SC/ST	0.223	0.225	-0.00	0.80	PC
Distance to BJY route (in KM)	26.557	485.101	-458.54	0.00	PC

Note: Some variables are only available at either the Assembly Constituency (AC) or Parliamentary Constituency (PC) level. The “Level” column indicates the level at which each variable is measured.

E.3 Robustness of Distance Analysis for State and National

In Table E.7, we show the p-values for our main specifications from Table 1 and 2 in the main text using Conley Standard Errors with different distance cut offs to adjust for spatial correlation, where errors are correlated across units that are geographically close to each other. Our effects are robust to this test across distance cutoffs.

F Karnataka Polling Station Data

We provide full details on the scraping and processing of our Karnataka polling station data. Form 20 provides election results at the polling station level for all contesting candidates in India. On average, each polling station has approximately 900 voters. There were 56,994 polling stations in the 2018 Karnataka assembly election. We scrape the data for the 2018 polling station-level results from the Karnataka Election Information System.²⁶ The website gives polling station-level votes for each candidate. We then manually mapped candidates to their political party using the state election data from TCPD. Due to some missingness, we have 54,433 polling stations in our data out of 56,994 in 2018. The data for the 2023 assembly election for the state of Karnataka is only available in PDF format on the website of the Chief Election Commissioner of Karnataka²⁷. We scrapped the PDF and

²⁶Karnataka Election Information, last accessed on 6th Aug 2024

²⁷Karnataka CEO, last accessed on 6th Aug 2024

Table E.1: Effect of Distance to the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in State Elections

	DV: Congress Vote Share			
	all state elections	elections 7 months since yatra	elections 11-13 months since yatra	elections 19 months since yatra
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
$\text{Log}(\text{Dist to BJY})_i \times \text{Post}_t$	-1.65*** (0.29)	-1.20** (0.59)	0.26 (0.32)	0.37 (0.32)
Observations	3747	891	2160	696
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
PC/AC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (AC)	948	224	549	175
Mean of DV	32.29	38.38	36.57	11.24

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the assembly constituency level. Karnataka elections were held 7 months after the yatra crossed the state, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Telangana elections were held 11-13 months after the yatra crossed their states, and Andhra Pradesh elections were held 19 months after the yatra crossed the state.

Table E.2: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Win in State Elections

	DV: Congress Win			
	all state elections	elections 7 months since yatra	elections 11-13 months since yatra	elections 19 months since yatra
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
$\text{BJY}_i \times \text{Post}_t$	0.12** (0.06)	0.18* (0.10)	0.07 (0.07)	0.001 (0.07)
Observations	3784	893	2195	696
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
AC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (AC)	948	224	549	175
Mean of DV	0.34	0.47	0.34	0.15

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the assembly constituency level. Karnataka elections were held 7 months after the yatra crossed the state, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Telangana elections were held 11-13 months after the yatra crossed their states, and Andhra Pradesh elections were held 19 months after the yatra crossed the state.

OCR and then manually cleaned the data to map the candidate with their political party.²⁸ In our data, we have 47,898 out of 58,282 polling stations in 2023.

The Form 20 polling station electoral data for Karnataka for 2018 and 2023 only mentions the assembly constituency number and polling station serial number. However, the polling station numbers do not necessarily remain the same for 2018 and 2023. For example, the number of polling stations has increased by 1,288 from 2018 to 2023. To overcome this challenge, we take the most conservative path and match the polling station over time using the name of the polling station. We obtained the names of 56,653 (out of 56,994) polling stations for 2018 Form 20 from online resources from Gaurav Sood who scrapped the polling station across India in 2018. The names of 58,198 (out of 58,282) polling stations for the 2023 elections were scrapped from Karnataka Election Information System.

We fuzzy-match polling stations using the names for 2018 and 2023. We iterate over all

²⁸Note that many of these websites are only accessible in India or with a VPN.

Table E.3: Effect of Yatra on INC Vote Share in National Elections (PC-Level)

	DV: Congress Vote Share			
	All States	Congress Always Contest(2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2024)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
BJY _i x Post _t	-0.55 (1.38)	-0.05 (1.34)	0.94 (1.60)	1.53 (1.52)
Observations	1598	1084	1145	900
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
PC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (PC)	501	271	317	232
Mean of DV	28.93	33.81	29.57	33.15

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the parliamentary constituency level. Model 1 includes all constituencies for the state that we cover. Model 2 subsets to only constituencies where Congress contested in all 4 elections, Model 3 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats across all 4 elections. Model 4 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats in the 2024 elections.

Table E.4: Effect of Yatra on INC Win in National Elections (PC-Level)

	DV: Congress WIN			
	All States	Congress Always Contest(2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2024)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
BJY _i x Post _t	0.02 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.04)	0.02 (0.03)	0.001 (0.04)
Observations	4183	2162	2529	1848
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
PC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (PC)	529	271	319	232
Mean of DV	0.09	0.13	0.1	0.09

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the parliamentary constituency level. Model 1 includes all constituencies for the state that we cover. Model 2 subsets to only constituencies where Congress contested in all 4 elections, Model 3 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats across all 4 elections. Model 4 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats in the 2024 elections.

assembly constituencies one by one and successfully match over 50% of the polling stations. To verify our match, we look at the correlation between polling station numbers in 2018 and 2023, as only a small fraction of polling stations changed their numbers, the polling station serial number for the vast majority should remain the same. The correlation for the names matched without a single difference in a name string is 99.24% while for names matched with at most 10 character difference in the name is 97.3%. Right now, this is the most conservative approach to matching.

G Google Trends

We collect search behavior for the following topics: Bharat Jodo Yatra, Rahul Gandhi, Indian National Congress, Narendra Modi, and Bharatiya Janata Party. These Google Trends Topics include a group of terms that share the same concept in any language. This ensures that we capture the entire search pattern on the Google platform, regardless of

Table E.5: Effect of Distance to the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections (PC-Level)

	DV: Congress Vote Share			
	All States	Congress Always Contest	Congress Strongholds States (2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2024)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Log(Dist to BJY) _i x Post _t	-0.09 (0.53)	0.03 (0.55)	-1.31** (0.62)	-0.77 (0.62)
Observations	1598	1084	925	900
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
AC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (PC)	501	271	239	232
Mean of DV	28.93	33.81	32.99	33.15

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the parliamentary constituency level. Model 1 includes all constituencies for the state that we cover. Model 2 subsets to only constituencies where Congress contested in all 4 elections, Model 3 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats across all 4 elections. Model 4 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats in the 2024 elections.

Table E.6: Effect Distance to the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Congress Vote Share in National Elections (AC-Level)

	DV: Congress Vote Share			
	All States	Congress Always Contest(2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2009-2024)	Congress Strongholds States (2024)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Log(Dist to BJY) _i x Post _t	-0.85*** (0.20)	-0.66*** (0.20)	-1.56*** (0.24)	-1.30*** (0.23)
Observations	12328	8608	9421	7622
Year FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
PC/AC FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓
Number of Clusters (AC)	3743	2157	2576	1973
Mean of DV	30.66	34.33	31.61	34.04

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the assembly constituency level. Model 1 includes all constituencies for the state that we cover. Model 2 subsets to only constituencies where Congress contested in all 4 elections, Model 3 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats across all 4 elections. Model 4 focuses on states where Congress contested in 80% or more of the seats in the 2024 elections.

Table E.7: P-values Different Cutoff Distances (Conley Standard Errors)

Distance Cutoff in KMs	P-Value							
	All (VS)	Karnataka(VS)	Telangana, MP, Raj. (VS)	Andhra (VS)	All (LS-AC)	LS Strongholds(AC)	All (LS-PC)	LS-PC Strongholds
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
5	0	0.0402	0.4178	0.2533	0.0015	0	0.8626	0.0368
10	0	0.0319	0.4913	0.2567	0.0195	0	0.8640	0.0407
25	0.0010	0.0275	0.5752	0.3141	0.1442	0.0049	0.8773	0.0770
30	0.0020	0.0085	0.5920	0.3625	0.1693	0.0077	0.8819	0.0841
40	0.0046	0.0176	0.6179	0.4027	0.2130	0.0138	0.8894	0.0873
50	0.0091	0.0158	0.6313	0.4209	0.2491	0.0218	0.8947	0.0998
75	0.0229	0.0345	0.6427	0.3513	0.3188	0.0456	0.9068	0.1527
100	0.0323	0.0211	0.6350	0.1810	0.3653	0.0627	0.9168	0.1852

the language or similar wording used to search for it. Google Trends measures an interest from citizens in search terms related to the yatra, rather than evidence of media coverage. Google Trends does not provide raw search totals; instead, it offers data that has already been transformed using min-max normalization from 0 to 100. The dependent variable will

take a value of 100 when the maximum ratio of BJJ topic searches to all Google searches is achieved, and 0 when it is at its minimum. We collect daily data for all Indian states from September 6, 2022, to January 31, 2023, from one day before the BJJ began to one day after it ended.

We examine the effect of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on Google searches using an event study at the state-day level. This analysis tests the dynamic treatment effects of the yatra entering a state on political interest in a search topic. When the yatra entered a state, we observed a large increase in search interest for the Bharat Jodo Yatra and Rahul Gandhi, and a smaller increase for the Indian National Congress in the days following entry. For each of these terms, interest levels return to pre-yatra baselines approximately 15–20 days after the yatra.

Table G.1 shows the difference-in-difference effect of the yatra entering a state on daily Google trends searches.

Table G.1: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Daily Google Search Rate

	DV: Search Popularity Index				
	BJJ	Rahul Gandhi	INC	Narendra Modi	BJP
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
$BJJ_i \times Post_t$	46.49*** (6.73)	45.32*** (3.19)	3.91*** (1.24)	0.32 (0.70)	2.92* (1.52)
Observations	4144	4144	4440	4884	4588
State FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Day FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Mean of DV	8.65	16.06	12.88	6.31	14.4

Notes: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. SEs clustered at the state level. The variable *Post* equals 1 only while the Yatra is physically present in a given state, and switches to 0 once it leaves.

For the Google Trends event study in the main text, we present the results using the Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) method. Compared to other popular DiD estimators, the Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) method is particularly appropriate for analyzing the effect of Rahul Gandhi’s entry into Indian states on Google Trends popularity data due to its explicit modeling of staggered treatment timing and flexible estimation of group-time average treatment effects. Unlike two-way fixed effects (TWFE), which is known to produce biased estimates in staggered settings due to negative weighting and contamination from already-treated units, the Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) approach uses only appropriate comparison groups (e.g., not-yet-treated or never-treated states) for each treated group at each time. While *did2s* (Gardner 2022) and *sunab* (Sun and Abraham 2021) correct for TWFE biases and allow dynamic estimation, they focus primarily on event-time effects and assume a homogeneous dynamic treatment path across groups. In contrast, Callaway and

Table G.2: Effect Bharat Jodo Yatra on Daily Google Search Rate (Post==1 Always)

	DV: Search Popularity Index				
	BJY	Rahul Gandhi	INC	Narendra Modi	BJP
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
$BJY_i \times Post_t$	13.54*** (3.39)	11.77*** (2.97)	-0.48 (0.79)	0.17 (0.38)	-0.79 (0.99)
Observations	4144	4144	4440	4884	4588
State FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Day FEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Mean of DV	8.65	16.06	12.88	6.31	14.4

Notes: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the state level. Here, the variable **Post** switches to 1 once the Yatra enters a state and remains 1 thereafter, even after it has moved on.

Sant’Anna’s method allows for treatment effect heterogeneity across both groups and time, making it better suited when different states may react differently or at different speeds to Rahul Gandhi’s entry. This makes it the most appropriate method when both staggered timing and treatment effect heterogeneity are central concerns. Still, in Figures G.1, G.2, and G.3 we present the event study using alternative approaches and find similar results.

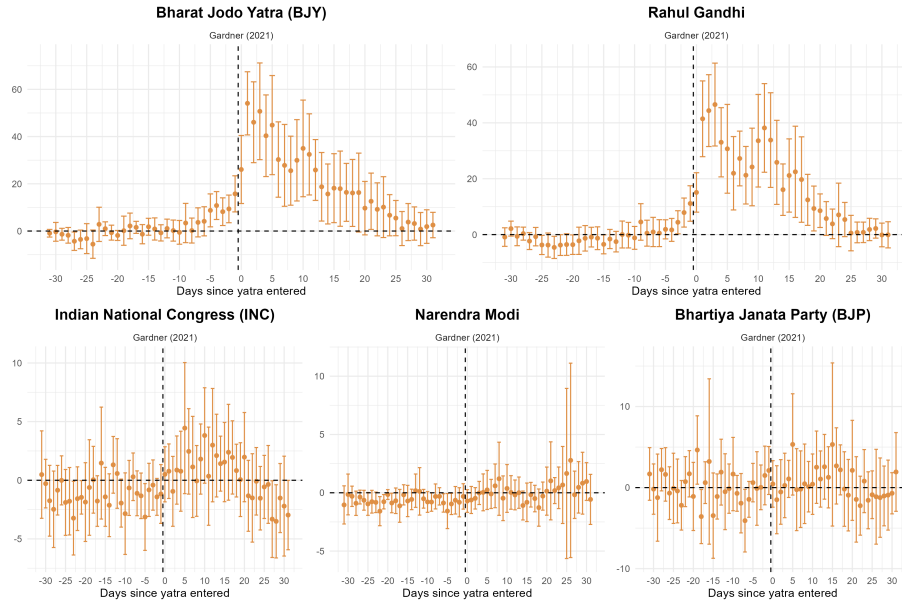


Figure G.1: Impacts of BGY on Google Search Outcomes (Gardner 2022)

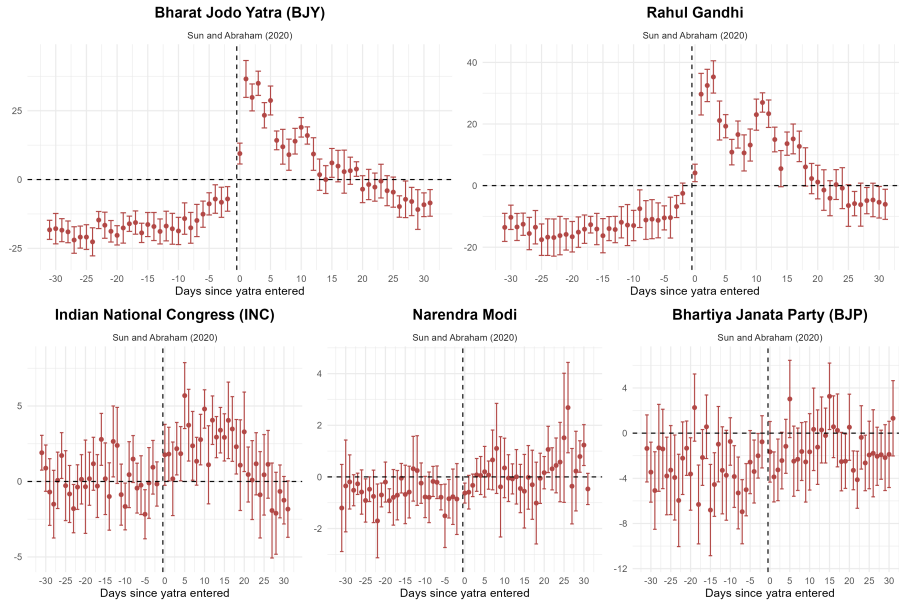


Figure G.2: Impacts of BJJ on Google Search Outcomes (Sun and Abraham 2021)

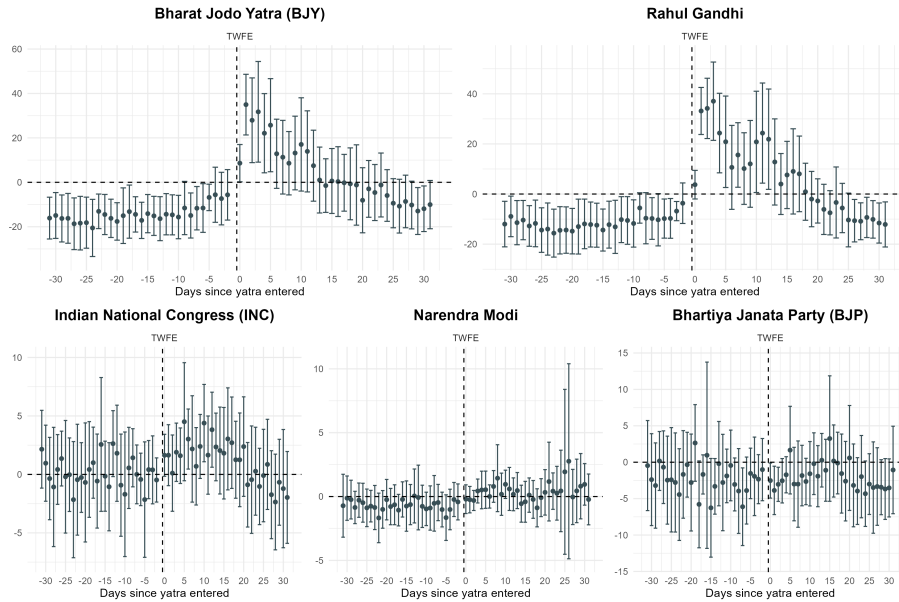


Figure G.3: Impacts of BJJ on Google Search Outcomes (TWFE)

H Matching

H.1 Combined Diagnostic Panel

Figure H.1 presents four diagnostic checks for the propensity score matching procedure, estimated using 1:2 nearest-neighbor matching with a 0.2 standard deviation caliper.

Panel A shows the distribution of estimated propensity scores for treated units (blue), matched controls (green), and unmatched controls (gray). The strong overlap between treated and matched control distributions indicates adequate common support. Matched controls are concentrated in the 0.10–0.20 range, where treated units are most prevalent, suggesting successful matching. Unmatched controls fall largely below 0.10, confirming that the caliper restriction effectively excluded poor matches.

Panel B displays a jitter plot of propensity scores by treatment status. Matched controls cluster within the common support region (0.10–0.25), substantially overlapping with treated units, whereas unmatched controls exhibit systematically lower scores. This pattern confirms that matching identified comparable control observations while excluding dissimilar ones.

Panel C presents the covariate balance assessment using a Love plot of absolute standardized mean differences (SMDs) before (red circles) and after (green triangles) matching. The dashed vertical line marks the conventional threshold of 0.1. All covariates show substantial improvement in balance, with post-matching SMDs well below 0.1 for every variable. The largest pre-matching imbalance appears in `distance` (the propensity score itself), which is reduced to near zero after matching. Both binary indicators (`gen_d`, `sc_d`, `st_d`) and continuous variables (`enop`, `turnout`, `inc_vs`) achieve satisfactory balance, indicating that the matching procedure effectively balanced observed covariates.

Panel D reports the empirical cumulative distribution functions (ECDFs) of propensity scores for treated and matched control units. The two curves nearly overlap across the full range, with only minor divergence around 0.15–0.20, demonstrating strong distributional similarity and comparable likelihoods of treatment assignment.

Overall, the diagnostics confirm that the matching procedure achieved excellent covariate balance and common support, satisfying key assumptions for valid causal inference in the subsequent difference-in-differences analysis.

H.2 Distributional Balance Diagnostics

Figure H.2 presents quantile-quantile (Q-Q) plots comparing the treated and matched control distributions for each covariate. Points on the 45-degree dashed line represent perfect distributional equivalence between the two groups. Overall, the plots show close alignment

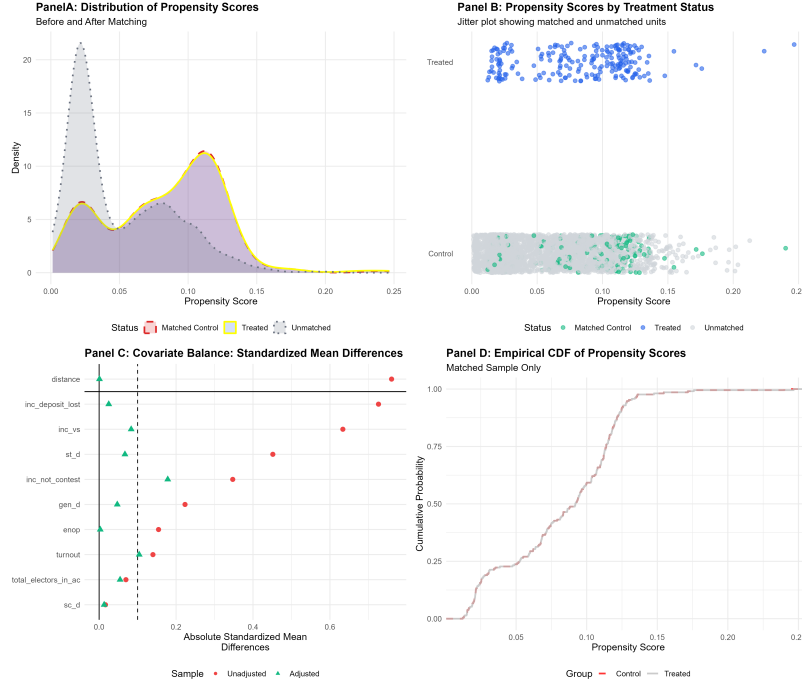


Figure H.1: Combined Diagnostic Panel

along the diagonal, indicating that the matching procedure achieved strong balance not only in means but across the full distributions of the covariates.

Continuous Variables

For continuous covariates, the Q-Q plots confirm excellent distributional similarity. The variable **enop** (Effective Number of Parties) shows a tight alignment along the diagonal, with only minor deviations in the upper tail, suggesting comparable levels of party system fragmentation. The **inc_vs** (INC Vote Share) plot exhibits particularly strong balance, with points clustered closely around the 45-degree line and similar ranges (0–80%) across groups. The **total_electors_in_ac** (Constituency Size) plot also demonstrates good balance across quantiles, with only slight dispersion around mid-level quantiles, indicating that treated and control constituencies are similar in size. Finally, **turnout** (Voter Turnout) displays near-perfect alignment between 45–90%, confirming that both central and tail distributions of voter participation are highly comparable.

Binary Indicators

For binary indicators, the step-like shapes in the Q-Q plots reflect their discrete nature, yet the points remain close to the diagonal, indicating balanced proportions between treated and control groups. Specifically, **gen_d** (General Constituency) and **sc_d** (Scheduled Caste

Reserved) both exhibit strong alignment, confirming that reservation status is well balanced across matched samples. Similarly, `st_d` (Scheduled Tribe Reserved) shows balance despite the smaller number of ST-reserved constituencies. The variables `inc_deposit_lost` and `inc_not_contest` also follow the diagonal closely, demonstrating comparable rates of incumbent deposit loss and non-contestation.

Interpretation Summary

Taken together, the Q-Q plots show that the matching procedure successfully achieved distributional balance beyond simple mean equivalence. The clustering of points along the 45-degree line across all variables, both continuous and binar indicates that treated and matched control units share nearly identical full distributions. This finding reinforces the credibility of subsequent treatment effect estimation by ensuring that observable characteristics are well matched not only on average but across their entire support.

H.3 Overall Assessment

The diagnostic results collectively provide strong evidence that the matching procedure generated a credible comparison group:

1. **Common Support:** Adequate overlap in propensity score distributions between treated and control units (Panels A and B of Figure H.1).
2. **Covariate Balance:** All covariates (except INC Not Contest, which is still < 0.2 , acceptable) achieve standardized mean differences (SMD) below 0.1 after matching (Panel C of Figure H.1).
3. **Distributional Similarity:** Q-Q plots demonstrate close alignment along the 45-degree line for all covariates (Figure H.2).
4. **Propensity Score Balance:** Empirical cumulative distribution functions (ECDFs) of treated and control units nearly coincide (Panel D of Figure H.1).

Overall, the 1:1 nearest-neighbor matching with caliper restriction effectively eliminated systematic differences in observed covariates between treated and control groups. Consequently, treatment effect estimates derived from the matched sample can be interpreted as causal under the standard assumption of no unobserved confounding.

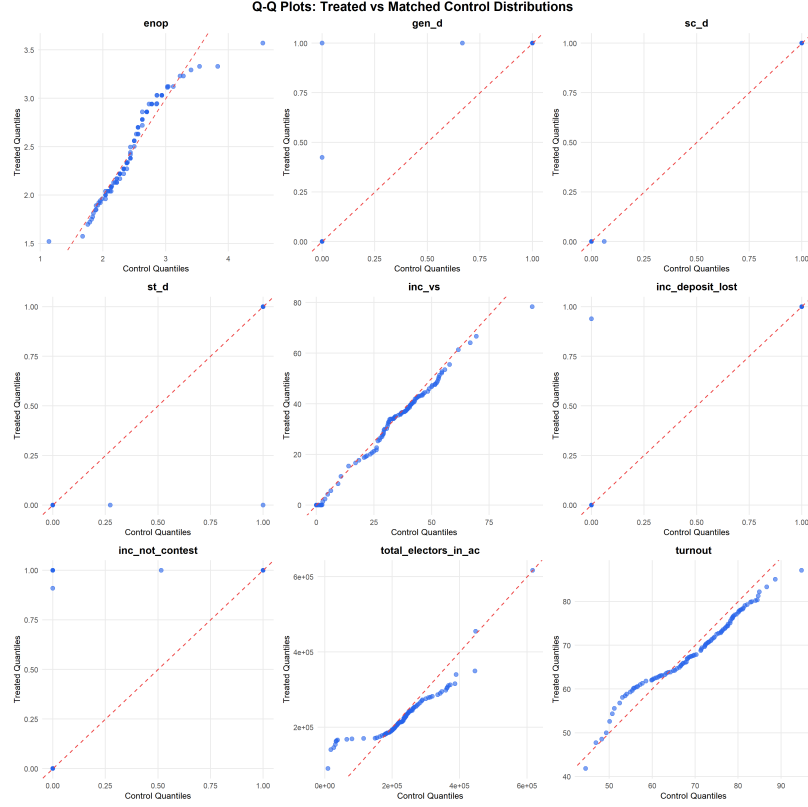


Figure H.2: Distributional Balance Diagnostics

Table H.1: Covariate Balance Before and After Matching

Variable	<u>Before Matching</u>			<u>After Matching</u>		
	Treated	Control	Std. Diff.	Treated	Control	Std. Diff.
Propensity Score	0.199	0.120	0.762	0.190	0.190	0.003
Effective Number of Parties	2.477	2.443	0.075	2.445	2.460	-0.034
Share of GEN Constituency	0.761	0.758	0.005	0.754	0.841	-0.204
Share of SC Constituency	0.169	0.153	0.044	0.174	0.116	0.155
Share of ST Constituency	0.070	0.089	-0.073	0.072	0.043	0.113
INC Vote Share	29.786	17.967	0.736	29.701	29.612	0.005
INC Deposit Lost	0.197	0.542	-0.868	0.203	0.217	-0.036
INC Did Not Contest	0.113	0.242	-0.407	0.116	0.116	0.000
Total Electors in PC	1735950	1670971	0.191	1720353	1738025	-0.052
Voter Turnout	66.934	68.255	-0.105	68.026	68.901	-0.070

H.4 Matching Parliamentary Constituency

I Phone Survey

I.1 Survey Methodology and Details

The survey was administered by CVoter, an Indian public opinion research firm, in January 2024, approximately fifteen months after the yatra passed through Karnataka and thirteen months after it passed through Madhya Pradesh. CVoter added the questions to regular omnibus surveys that use random digit dialing. CVoter provides post-stratification weights to achieve representativeness on age, gender, education, income, social group, and rurality for each state. In all of our analyses, we use these weights.

In Karnataka, we surveyed 420 respondents in 20 assembly constituencies where the yatra passed and 896 respondents across a random sample of 40 assembly constituencies where the yatra did not pass through. In Madhya Pradesh, we surveyed 965 respondents across 18 assembly constituencies where the yatra passed and 1,229 respondents across a random sample of 42 assembly constituencies where the yatra did not pass through. Figure I.1 shows the ACs for which we have survey respondents. Stratifying the sample on places that the yatra did and did not cross allowed us to obtain enough respondents who could have participated directly in the yatra.

The survey was approved by [Redacted University]’s Institutional Review Board.

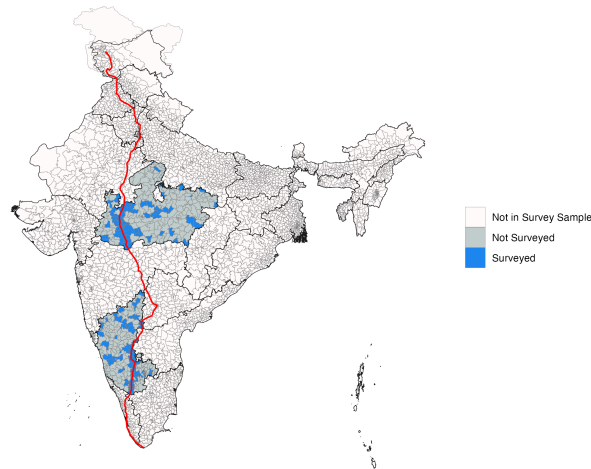


Figure I.1: Map of ACs in our Survey Data

We focus on 4 different subsets of respondents:

- All respondents
- BJP 2019 supporters: those who reported that they voted for the BJP when asked which party they supported in the 2019 Lok Sabha election
- INC 2019 supporters: those who reported that they voted for the INC when asked which party they supported in the 2019 Lok Sabha election
- BJY ACs respondents: those who were in assembly constituencies that they yatra passed through

We look at several outcome variables from the survey. Here we list each question for the outcomes.

- How has your opinion of Rahul Gandhi been in the past year - improved, stayed the same, worsened, don't know / can't say
- How has your opinion of the Congress Party been in the past year - improved, stayed the same, worsened, don't know / can't say
- How satisfied are you with the performance of Congress leader, Rahul Gandhi in the past year - very much satisfied, satisfied to some extent, not at all satisfied, don't know / can't say
- In the past year, did you feel that the INC was unified and had less infighting - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political engagement with INC (did at least one of the following):
 - Receive any political messages from Congress by phone - yes, no, don't know, refused
 - Attend a Congress political meeting or election rally - yes, no, don't know, refused
 - Get contacted by a party worker from Congress - yes, no, don't know, refused
 - Attended a rally by a state leader - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political discourse about Rahul Gandhi (did at least one of the following)
 - Heard Rahul Gandhi discussed on television/phone - yes, no, don't know, refused
 - Discussed Rahul Gandhi with neighbors - yes, no, don't know, refused
- In the past year, did you feel that the BJP was unified and had less infighting - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political engagement with BJP (did at least one of the following):
 - Receive any political messages from BJP by phone - yes, no, don't know, refused

- Attend a BJP political meeting or election rally - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Get contacted by a party worker from BJP - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Attended a rally by a state leader - yes, no, don't know, refused
- Any political discourse about Narendra Modi (did at least one of the following)
 - Heard Narendra Modi discussed on television/phone - yes, no, don't know, refused
 - Discussed Narendra Modi with neighbors - yes, no, don't know, refused
- If the Lok Sabha election was held today, which party would you vote for?
- Which party did you vote for in the 2023 Vidhan Sabha election?

I.2 Survey Robustness

In the main text, we examine the relationship between participation in the yatra and a range of political outcomes using our survey data. Here we demonstrate robustness to conducting the analysis only on the Karnataka sample (Figure I.2), only on the Mahdya Pradesh sample (Figure I.3), and with controls (Figure I.4).

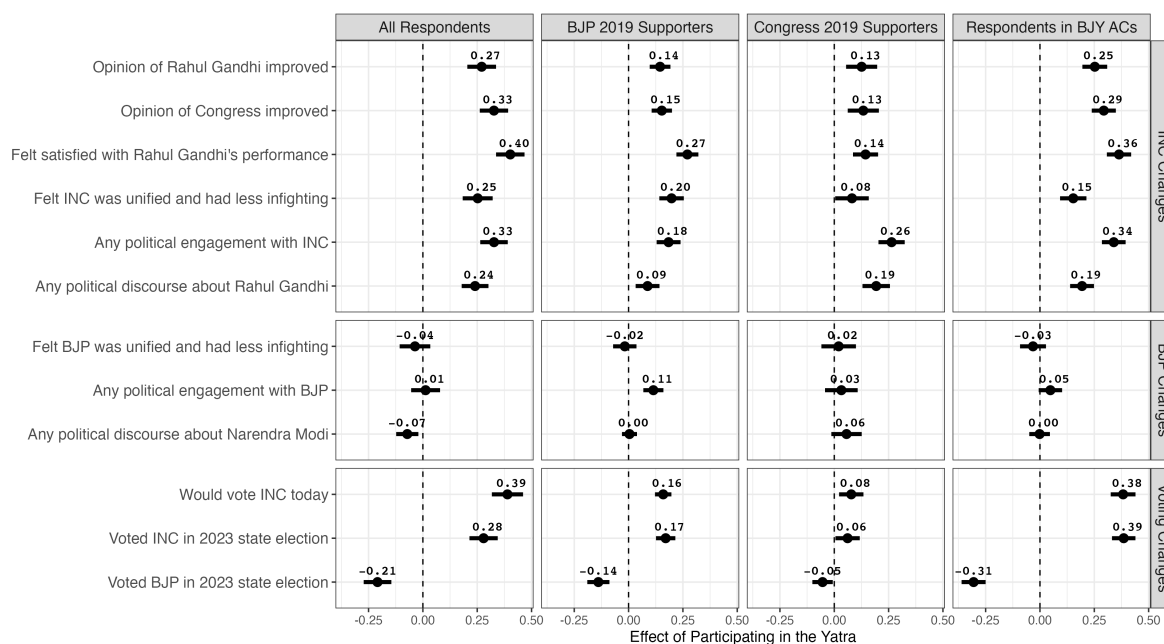


Figure I.2: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes (only Karnataka Sample)

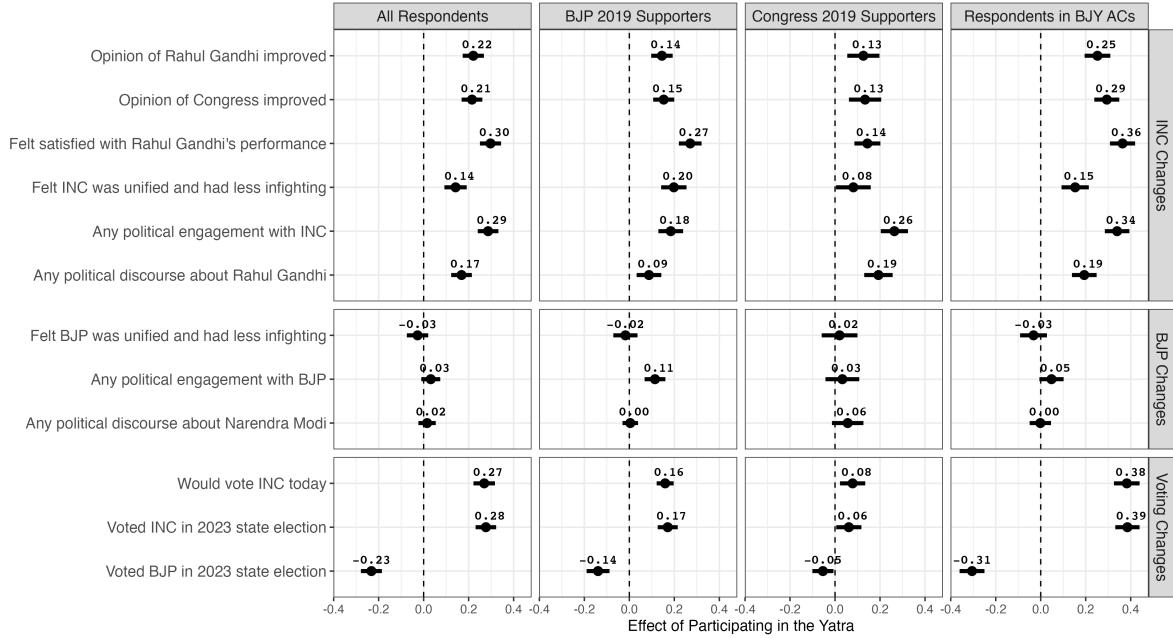


Figure I.3: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes (only Madhya Pradesh Sample)

J Description of Interview Approach

To supplement our understanding of the Bharat Jodo Yatra and the mechanisms for increased Congress voter share we conducted 20 interviews with party leaders and workers, civil society organization leaders, and voters, primarily in Karnataka, seven months after the election (additional interviews were also conducted over the phone and in Delhi with party functionaries involved in the overall BJY process). The party and organizational interviewees were sampled through a snowball sample from reaching out to initial party officials and from visiting the Congress party office in Bangalore. The voters were sampled in both Bangalore district and Mysore district through a snowball sample as well. These interviews are not structured to qualitatively test our argument but rather to supplement our understanding and ground-truth the mechanism for the BJY effects. We further recognize that party functionaries may describe the yatra impact in a particular way, so the interview evidence should be interpreted as perceptions of individuals rather than conclusive evidence of yatra changes. The interviews was approved by [Redacted University]'s Institutional Review Board.

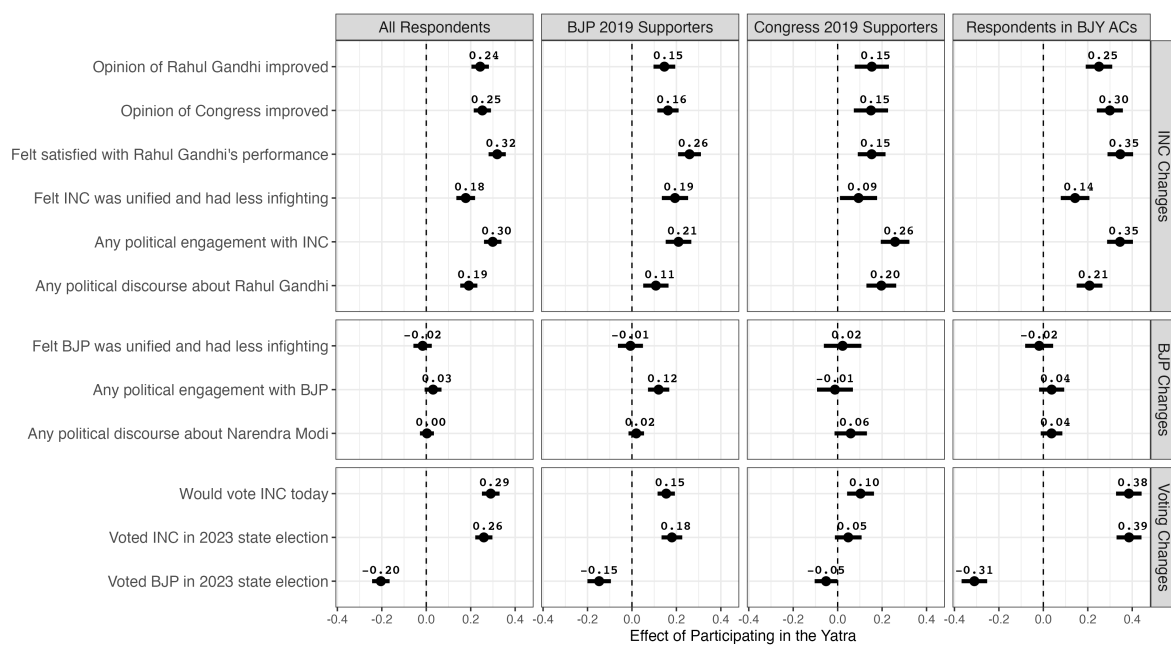


Figure I.4: Relationship between Participating in the Yatra and Political Outcomes (with Controls)